



PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

FIRST MEETING, 2026

Monday, 9th March, 2026

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 10:21 a.m.*

[HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER,
MR BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE
CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we move to the correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I have the *Votes and Proceedings* of Thursday, 5th March, 2026, for correction.

Page 1...13.

Yes, Hon Member?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I was marked absent even though I was present on the said date. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table Office, take note.

Hon Members, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Thursday, 5th March,

2026, as corrected is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

We also have *Official Report* of Thursday, 26th February, 2026 for correction.

[No correction was made to the Official Report of Thursday, 26th February, 2026]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Members, may I ask the Minister for Health to take the designated seat, to respond to the Questions scheduled for him. Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, before we begin, I feel it is important—We on this Side of the House have often called for the presence of Ministers to come do Business. I want to acknowledge and commend the Minister for Health. When I entered the Chamber at half past nine o'clock, he was here. So, I want to commend him. I think he is taking a cue from the Minister for Road and Highways. I hope the other Ministers will take a cue from these two Ministers. That is what the Minority has always been calling for, that is the presence of the Ministers. So that our oversight cannot be undermined.

Mr Speaker, it is impressive and I want to commend him. I hope he will not slack but sustain this.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

Hon Members, the Hon Minister for Health is scheduled to respond to two

Urgent Questions. The first Urgent Question stands in the name of the Hon Member for Effutu.

Yes, Hon Member?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I have his authorisation to ask the Question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please do.

URGENT QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF HEALTH

Measures Taken to Contain Rising Mpox Infections in the Country

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu on behalf of the Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Health, what immediate measures the Ministry is implementing to contain the rising Mpox infection, as confirmed by the Ghana Health Service at 880 cases as of 25th November, 2025.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister.

Minister for Health (Mr Kwabena Mintah Akandoh) (MP): Mr Speaker, I thank the Hon Member of Parliament for Effutu, the Minority Leader, who is ably represented by the First Deputy Minority Whip for asking the Question, on the immediate measures being implemented to contain the Mpox infections.

Mpox is a zoonotic infection and remains a public health concern globally and on the African continent. Since the outbreak began in May 2025, the Ministry of Health, through the Ghana Health Service and with partner support, has activated a coordinated multi-sectorial response aimed at interrupting transmission and protecting public health.

For clarity, while 880 cases had been confirmed as of 25th November, 2025, the situation updates as of 3rd March, 2026 is that Ghana has recorded 1,038 confirmed cases and 8 deaths, largely among persons with underlying health conditions. There are 124 districts across all regions, representing 47.51 per cent, which have reported confirmed cases, with the Greater Accra and Western Regions being the most affected. There is currently one case on admission with no critical cases.

The response is being implemented through strengthened coordination and emergency operations. Intensified surveillance and contact tracing with 21-day follow-up and sustained laboratory testing at the National Public Health Reference Laboratory, the Noguchi Memorial Institute for Medical Research and the Kumasi Centre for Collaborative Research Case Management and Infection Prevention and Control have also been reinforced, including supervised home isolation for mild cases and management of moderate to severe cases in designated facilities with support from the Ghana Infection Disease Centre.

In addition, risk communication and community engagement have been intensified through public education and engagement with community leaders, civil society and the media. On vaccination, reactive vaccinations have been implemented in identified households among high-risk contacts.

Ghana received 33,600 Mpox vaccines from Africa Centre for Diseases Control and Prevention (CDC) and World Health Organization (WHO) and 31,231 persons have been vaccinated across 12 districts in the Ashanti, Greater Accra and Western Regions, achieving coverage exceeding 95 per cent of the target population.

Government has further ensured that medical bills relating to the patient care during this outbreak are covered by the state, so that no cost is passed on to the affected persons.

Mr Speaker, these interventions are yielding results. Although sporadic cases have been recorded over the past two months, the overall trend shows a significant decline following the introduction of vaccination.

10:31 a.m.

Average weekly cases have reduced from 28 cases per week to 7 cases per week and there is currently only one case on admission with no critical cases. Mpox is also no longer classified as public health emergency of international concern. Government remains committed to sustaining the response and strengthening the country's health

security architecture and Hon Members are encouraged to support this nation of accurate information to our people.

Mr Speaker, thank you

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Hon Minister, in your Answer you said 41 districts have been affected. Would you mind making these districts known?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, this would have been a specific question so that the Minister can list all of them to come and tell us. If you want him to *viva voce*, tell us he made a mistake, that will surely be a problem.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I am guided. But the Minister, in his Answer said that 41 districts have been affected and Northern and Greater Accra Regions are the highly affected regions. So, just for—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: This is because your question is seeking the list of the 41 and you know the list of the 41 is a lot.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I will not belabour it. Hon Kwabena Mintah Akandoh is my former Friend so I would just—

Prof Kingsley Nyarko: Mr Speaker, thanks for indulging me. Hon Minister, thank you for the elaborate response. I would like to find out from you what is accounting for the increase in the number

of cases in the Greater Accra Region. I heard you say that Greater Accra has increasing numbers, if I heard you correctly. So, if you could give us reasons why.

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, for the record, in my Answer, I indicated that 124 districts across all regions and that constitutes 47.5 per cent and not 47 districts and so that is it. The next issue has to do with the regions that are most affected, that is the Western and Greater Accra Regions. I think largely it is also due to the population density in these areas. The spread is moved from animals to humans and one human will also take it to the other. So, basically it has to do with the population density of the areas.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, thank you very much. Hon Minister, we are aware Monkey Pox is a viral disease, but in your Answer, you placed emphasis on vaccination. Respectfully, I would want to find out, is the Ministry considering other options of providing prevention rather than just vaccination and how are you doing that?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, vaccination is also part of the prevention measures. So, to prevent the disease, if we have a greater proportion of the targeted population vaccinated, you break the transmission in the first place.

Mr Speaker, it is also very important for us to intensify education. So that when people experience their symptoms, they will report to the nearest health facilities and do not stay until the conditions are worsened before they go

to the nearest facility. So, education is key and at the moment, we are intensifying education on the television and radio stations and information centres in the communities. I would also encourage Hon Members to also get on board so that they can also educate their constituents.

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: It is refreshing to hear the Minister encouraging Hon Members to get on board. That should be it. But I am interested in knowing if he has started some engagement with Members or he intends to engage us to put us in a position to be able to get on board effectively as it were. Is this something he is considering?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Akandoh: Yes, Mr Speaker, I am considering that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, Hon Jerry Ahmed Shaib, you have had your bite. There cannot be a follow-up on a follow-up question. It is not done.

Let us move to question number—Yes, Hon Dafeamekpor?

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I find out from the Minister if there is some deliberate policy position of the Ministry to assure the nation and also issue a sanitation directive on this matter, especially across our borders. The people are agitated about this matter. Can you—we have allowed you, the Minority

to ask all your supplementary questions. So, allow Mr Speaker to rule on this matter.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Majority Chief Whip you have heard the indication.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, their indication is not your indication.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The question is not about policy. You are talking about policy. Hon Members, let us move to Urgent Question 7 (b), standing in the name of Prof Kingsley Nyarko, Member of Parliament for Kwadaso. He is my very good Friend.

Measures to Expedite Treatment of Miss Sandra Baafi Boateng

Prof Kingsley Nyarko (NPP — Kwadaso): Mr Speaker, we are more than friends, we are brothers with occasional fights.

Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Health the measures the Ministry is putting in place to expedite the treatment and recovery of Miss Sandra Baafi Boateng, who was seriously injured and fell unconscious during the Ghana Armed Forces recruitment exercise held on 12/11/2025 at the Baba Yara Sports Stadium and has been on admission at the Komfo Anokye Teaching Hospital till now.

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, I thank the Hon Member for Kwadaso for the question and wish to assure this honourable House that the Minister of Health has remained actively engaged in

ensuring Komfo Anokye Teaching Hospital to ensure that Ms Sandra Baafi Boateng receives the requisite specialist care and that every necessary step is being taken to expedite her treatment and recovery. Without disclosing sensitive clinical details, I can confirm that the patient sustained serious injuries during the Ghana Armed Forces Recruitment exercise held on 12th November, 2025 at the Baba Yara Sports Stadium, following which she received inpatient care under specialist supervision. The measures being implemented to support her treatment and recovery include ensuring that her medical bills are fully covered by Government, so that no cost is passed on to the patient or her family. This has been complemented by comprehensive care delivered through a specialist-led multidisciplinary team, together with the required rehabilitation and related social support to optimise recovery.

Mr Speaker, the patient has, since 26th February, 2026, been transferred to the 37 Military Hospital for further management. Government is also considering all appropriate medical options, both locally and where necessary abroad, to ensure that she receives the best available care.

10:41 p.m.

Mr Speaker, in addition, the Ministry is facilitating the training and continuous capacity building of first responders to strengthen emergency response systems and improve outcomes for Ghanaians who may be affected by similar incidents. The Ministry of Health remains committed to supporting the

patient's full continuum of care. We will continue to work with the relevant health facilities and where necessary, engage other State institutions to ensure continuity of treatment, rehabilitation and appropriate follow-up until her condition stabilises sufficiently for discharge and subsequent outpatient management.

Mr Speaker, I so submit.

Prof Kingsley Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I thank the Minister for doing justice to Sandra Baafi Boateng's situation. I went to visit her about two months ago and her condition is precarious. I am also happy that she has been brought to 37 Military Hospital to receive enhanced—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We always fight because you refuse to take a cue from Standing Order 88(7). You cannot address the House. You have to ask a supplementary question.

Prof K. Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I know, but this is an emotional—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Whether emotional or not, that will not change the Rules.

Prof K. Nyarko: Mr Speaker, with the response that you are considering, the option of sending her abroad, will you expedite that option? Will you consider expediting that option of sending her abroad for enhanced medical care? Thank you.

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, we will be taking signals from the specialists, so as and when necessary, we will do accordingly.

Mr Patrick Boamah: Hon Minister, please when was the last time you visited this patient at that hospital and whether you have even visited her before? If so, when? Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Question is on measures being taken, what has it got to do with the Minister's visitation?

Mr Boamah: It is part of the issue. The Minister answered Questions on measures and I want to find out from the Minister whether he has ever visited the said patient in his capacity as the Health Minister and if so, when?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Does that Question emanate from measures?

Mr Boamah: Mr Speaker, the Minister is very capable of answering this simple Question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Question overruled.

Mr Boamah: Minister, you have not visited the patient?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I want to find out from the Minister whether he is visiting the patient as part of the measures he is putting in place?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Question overruled. The Minister clearly indicated in the Answer that it is under specialist care.

Hon Members, we thank the Hon Minister for responding to the Urgent Questions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have Oral Answers to Questions also scheduled for the Minister for Health.

The first Question stands in the name of Dr Kingsley Agyemang and that is the Question numbered 153. Please, you have the floor.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF HEALTH

Improving Oral Health in Ghana

Mr Frank Yeboah on behalf of Dr Kingsley Agyemang (Abuakwa South): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Health the plans of the Ministry to improve oral health as the 2023 WHO STEPS survey reveals a devastating state of oral health in Ghana.

Minister for Health (Mr Kwabena Mintah Akandoh) (MP): Mr Speaker, I am grateful to the Hon Member for Abuakwa South for the Question on the Ministry's plans to improve oral health, particularly in light of the findings of the 2023 WHO STEPS Survey.

The Survey points to a worrying oral health situation, including a high prevalence of oral health conditions of over 70 per cent, low utilisation of dental services of less than 10 per cent and poor oral hygiene practices affecting about 50 per cent of the population. In response, the Ministry of Health, working through its agencies, is pursuing strategic interventions to expand access, strengthen prevention and improve outcomes.

Mr Speaker, it is important to note that a number of dental treatments are already covered under the National Health Insurance Scheme. To further improve the situation, the Ministry has also integrated the health promotion, prevention and early detection aspects of dental care into the Free Primary Healthcare Programme. This is intended to strengthen community education, promote early identification of oral health conditions and ensure timely referral, particularly for underserved populations.

Ghana currently has fewer than 500 dentists for a population of over 34 million, with a concentration in urban centres. The Ministry is therefore prioritising the deployment of more dental professionals to underserved regions and the revamping of the ONUADO mobile dental clinics to deliver services to rural and hard-to-reach communities.

The Ministry is also leveraging technology to improve outcomes by intensifying the use of digital platforms and mobile applications for oral health promotion. These platforms will support public education on oral hygiene and facilitate remote interaction between patients and oral health professionals, especially where in-person services are limited.

Prevention and public education are being strengthened through mass media campaigns to promote regular dental check-ups, encourage fluoride use and support healthier behaviours, including reduced sugar consumption. The School

Health Education Programme will also be enhanced to instil lifelong oral hygiene habits in children from an early age.

10:51 p.m.

In addition, collaboration and system strengthening efforts are being intensified through partnerships with development agencies, the Ghana Dental Association, and international organisations to expand research, funding, and training opportunities. The Ministry will further develop training programmes for nurses and Physician Assistants to provide basic oral health services in remote areas, as part of a broader team-based approach to primary healthcare delivery.

Mr Speaker, improving oral health cannot be left to dentists alone. It requires a whole-of-society effort involving Government, policymakers, communities and traditional leaders, schools and educators, corporate bodies and the private sector, and individual citizens. Oral health is fundamental to overall health and wellbeing, and the Ministry remains committed to ensuring that access to preventive and basic oral healthcare improves across the country.

Mr Yeboah: The Minister made mention of the fact that some dental treatment is covered under the National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS). Can he be gracious enough to tell us some of the treatments that are covered under NHIS.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Are you talking about equipment?

Mr Yeboah: Under paragraph 3, line 2, the Hon Minister mentioned that some dental treatments are being covered under the NHIS, and I am asking if the Hon Minister can be gracious enough to let the House know the type of treatment that has been covered under NHIS?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, I do not have them off the top of my head, but within a few minutes I can get it. My officers are just behind me, they will get me the comprehensive list and I will communicate to the House.

Mr Yeboah: The Hon Minister is aware that Telemedicine has been implemented in the country. I just want to know from the Minister if dental treatment is part of the rollout of Telemedicine. In other words, do we have dentists under Telemedicine in Ghana now?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Ask a simple question so that the Minister can understand it. Supplementary questions do not allow you to ask convoluted questions. So, you have posed your question. Let the Hon Minister respond.

Mr Yeboah: Mr Speaker, I am guided.

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, dental care is part of the Telemedicine services we deliver in this country.

Mr Yeboah: May we know how many dental clinics or the specific dental clinics that are covered under this scheme?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please file a specific Question.

Nana Osei-Adjei: Mr Speaker, thank you very much, for the opportunity. In paragraph 4 of the Minister's Answer, with your kind permission, I read:

“The Ministry is therefore prioritising the deployment of more dental professionals to underserved regions and the revamping of the Onuado Mobile Dental Clinics to deliver services to rural and hard-to-reach communities.”

I want to find out from the Hon Minister when the prioritisation of the deployment of more professionals to these underserved regions will be concluded. Also—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, you have asked a question. Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, it is ongoing. At the moment, we have prioritised the underserved communities or districts in this country when it comes to deployment of health professionals. This is because we have seen that the majority of health professionals are overly concentrated in the cities.

Mr Osei-Adjei: When will the revamping of the Onuado Mobile Dental Clinics to communities like mine, be done?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But the Minister said it is ongoing. So, if you want to ask a specific question regarding your constituency, do so.

Mr Osei-Adjei: This is in relation to my constituency.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, so you can file a specific Question.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I have perused some statistics on oral health, and the findings are not the best.

Pursuant to the Hon Minister's response and per what I have captured from the statistics. It says that “84.9 per cent of adults have never received dental care.” My question then again is, what is the Minister doing to ensure that oral health care is promoted? How do we ensure that people get some dental care?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, I believe it has to do with education. A lot of us do not know how important it is to take our oral hygiene seriously. I was amazed to hear from a professional, a medical doctor, that there is a particular germ that can attack one's heart from one's mouth if the person does not have a very good oral hygiene. So, Mr Speaker, I believe that it is partly ignorance, because there are people who take their routine check-ups seriously, but they tend to ignore oral hygiene. So, we are going to intensify education on oral hygiene, starting from the schools.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I do not know if the Ministry on its own has started any

of these projects, including educating people. If yes, what is the structure? How do they intend to come to a constituency like my constituency? Because I keep getting more revealing statistics, and I am kind of worried.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: File a constituency-specific Question.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I only linked it to my constituency. I can take my constituency out, because I did not even mention the name of my constituency as Weija/Gbawe. So, my constituency is not the subject matter. Apart from education, and I know he said that he is engaging, I am asking what structures he has put in place so that it will be more comprehensive for people to be more engaged.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You are even worsening your case. You are talking about structures.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I am in your bosom.

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, as I indicated in my response, we are putting together a comprehensive approach today with this matter from the education bit from the schools to the media, information centres, and what have you. We are also looking at deploying enough professionals to the grounds. We are also looking at equipping the health facilities to be able to deal with issues of oral hygiene, like increasing the number of dental chairs in our various health facilities. It is a comprehensive package we are rolling out, especially with the

introduction of the Free Primary Healthcare. Thank you.

Prof K. Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I would like to find out from Hon Minister if the Ministry will ensure the training of more dentists. This is because the 500 that he mentioned is woefully not enough. So, the Ministry should think about ensuring that more of them are trained in the near future.

Mr Akandoh: It is part of the strategy.

11:01 a.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to Question numbered 154, standing in the name of Hon Dr Kingsley Agyemang.

Sustainable Financing Strategies for Public Health Emergency Response Amid Declining Donor Support

Mr Frank Yeboah on behalf of Dr Kingsley Agyemang (NPP — Abuakwa South): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Health what strategic plans the Ministry has developed to sustainably finance public health emergency response in the face of dwindling donor support, especially in light of the recent outbreaks such as Mpox, CSM and cholera.

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, I rise to respond to the Question by the Hon Member for Abuakwa South on the strategic plans the Ministry has developed to sustainably finance public health emergency preparedness and

response in the face of dwindling donor support, particularly in light of recent outbreaks such as Mpox, cerebrospinal meningitis and cholera.

Mr Speaker, Government recognises that the country can no longer rely predominantly on external assistance to finance critical public health functions. In that regard, following the withdrawal of USAID last year, His Excellency the President took a bold and decisive step by instructing the Minister for Finance to ensure that adequate resources are made available to the Ministry of Health to sustain and deliver the essential services that had been supported through USAID. In addition, allocations have been provided for within the National Health Insurance Fund allocation formula to support such priority public health activities and strengthen domestic financing for health security.

Mr Speaker, beyond these immediate domestic financing measures, the Ministry's strategy for sustainable funding is anchored on five practical interventions: First, the Ministry is ensuring the prudent utilisation of the Pandemic Fund Grant. Ghana secured this grant through the World Bank in 2024 to strengthen surveillance, laboratory systems, and workforce development over the next three years. These investments are intended to reduce response costs over time by strengthening preparedness and the speed of detection and containment.

Second, the Ministry is integrating public health emergency preparedness

and response more deliberately into national budgeting and development planning. This will ensure that core emergency preparedness activities are captured within medium-term plans and annual budgets, rather than being treated as ad hoc expenditures only when outbreaks occur.

Third, the Ministry will continue to invest in preparedness measures, including stockpiling, capacity building, simulation exercises, and enhanced surveillance. Evidence shows that stronger preparedness shortens outbreak duration and reduces overall costs.

Fourth, domestic resource mobilisation is being strengthened through structured engagement with relevant public and private institutions to support specific response needs when the situation demands, including logistics, testing support, and other critical inputs.

Fifth, the Ministry will deepen collaboration with institutional and research laboratories, including the Noguchi Memorial Institute for Medical Research, University of Health and Allied Sciences (UHAS), Kumasi Centre for Collaborative Research (KCCR), Council for Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR) and others, to sustain testing capacity for priority diseases and reduce reliance on externally funded laboratory support.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, while donor support has played an important role over the years, Government is taking deliberate steps to strengthen domestic

financing and ensure continuity of essential public health services. I wish to assure the House that the Ministry remains fully committed to building a resilient and sustainably financed public health emergency preparedness and response system.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary question?

Mr Yeboah: Mr Speaker, on paragraph 2, the Hon Minister sought to bring to our attention that the country can no longer rely predominantly on external assistance to finance critical public health. But if we go to the next page, where we have five main practical interventions, we have the Pandemic Fund Grant from the World Bank. How are we weaning ourselves from such funds so that in the future, they will not take it away from us and we will be found wanting? Thank you.

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, if I say we will not rely wholly on donor funding, what it means is that we have to take our own destiny into our hands. We must have a fallback plan. It must be a country-led project or programme so that, with or without foreign input, we will be able to deal with emergencies in this country. Thank you.

Mr Yeboah: Mr Speaker, no further questions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to Question

numbered 155, also standing in the name of Hon Dr Kingsley Agyemang.

NHIS Claims: Amounts and Types (2020–2023)

Mr Frank Yeboah on behalf of Dr Kingsley Agyemang (NPP — Abuakwa South): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Health to provide the claims amount for the years 2020-2023 and the types of claims for the respective years of the National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS).

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, I am grateful to the Hon Member for Abuakwa South for the Question on NHIS claims from 2020 to 2023, particularly the relationship between claims expenditure and claims paid, and what this implies for arrears. Mr Speaker, claims expenditure represents the value of services claimed in a given year, while claims paid represent what is actually settled in that same year. Where claims paid fall below claims expenditure, the unpaid balance becomes arrears. Where claims paid exceed claims expenditure, it is typically because arrears from previous years are being cleared.

Mr Speaker, the claims paid over the period were as follows: GHC1,372.82 million in 2020, GHC1,101.28 million in 2021, GHC963.23 million in 2022, and GHC2,252.08 million in 2023. This shows a decline in payments up to 2022, before a significant rebound in 2023.

Analysis of Claims Payment from 2020 to 2023				
Year	Claims Expenditure GH¢'m	Claims Paid GH¢'m	Portion of Payment relating to Current Year GH¢'m	Portion of Payment relating to Previous Years GH¢'m
2020	1,001.32	1,372.82	473.00	899.82
2021	1,129.74	1,101.28	469.51	631.77
2022	1,602.20	963.23	328.73	634.50
2023	1,810.35	2,252.08	1,132.67	1,119.41

Mr Speaker, the most critical year was 2022. Claims expenditure that year was GH¢1,602.20 million, while claims paid were GH¢963.23 million, creating a shortfall of about GH¢638.97 million. This shortfall translated directly into increased arrears and heightened pressure on service providers. The subsequent increase in payments in 2023 reflects, in part, the need to clear accumulated arrears from earlier years.

Mr Speaker, the current Government is committed to restoring payment discipline and improving claims management so that annual claims expenditure is more consistently matched by payments, arrears are prevented from building up, and providers can deliver services to NHIS members without disruption.

Mr Speaker, this commitment is already being reflected in improved payment performance. In 2025, claims processing and payment accelerated to the point that payments were made faster

than the three-month window stipulated under the NHIS Act. In the same year, a total of GH¢2,688.6 million was paid to service providers, in addition to the transfer of GH¢1.5 billion to the Ghana Medical Trust Fund.

Mr Speaker, we have the year, claims expenditure, claims paid, portion of the payment relating to that year, and portions of payment relating to previous years. So, the Hon Member may follow it carefully, in 2020, whilst the claims expenditure was GH¢1 billion, about GH¢1.3 billion was paid. But Mr Speaker, only GH¢473 million was in respect to 2020, the rest were arrears. I hope Mr Speaker is following.

We would move to 2021. When we go to 2021, whilst the claims expenditure is about GH¢1.1 billion, claims paid is also GH¢1.1 billion, but claims relating to 2021 that was paid was GH¢469 million. What does it mean? It means we were piling up arrears. In 2022, the claims payment was GH¢1.6 billion,

amount paid was GH¢963 million. Out of the GH¢963 million that was paid, only GH¢328 million was with respect to 2022. What it means is that we were piling up arrears.

11:11 a.m.

Mr Speaker, again, when we came to 2023, it was GH¢1.8 billion and then GH¢2.2 billion was paid and the proportion with respect to 2023 was GH¢1.1 billion, while the rest was the arrears.

So, Mr Speaker, over the years, we have been piling up arrears and this is what we are doing differently. Now the narrative is different. We are no more piling up arrears. We are paying on time; we are paying promptly.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary question?

Mr Yeboah: Thank you, Mr Speaker, and thank you, Hon Minister, for the analysis.

While you attempted to attribute the non-payment or the arrears, you failed to recognise the fact that in 2020, the claims expenditure was GH¢1 billion and the amount paid is GH¢1.3 billion, which recognises the fact that there were arrears from prior years. No doubt about that. 2021, GH¢1.1 billion and claims paid were GH¢1.1 billion. So, I just want the House to recognise the fact that in 2020—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you are violating Order 88(7)(a).

Mr Yeboah: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

The question is that in 2025, Minister, can you tell this House, if they—
[Interruption] I understand, please. In 2025 year, can you tell this House that the payment that was made in respect of claims by the National Health Insurance Authority did not include arrears?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: This supplementary question is overruled.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, a while ago, you referenced Order 88(7)(a) and you admonished the Member. Yes, Mr Speaker, the interpretation of the rules is in your bossom, but where the Minister has provided Answers and the Member is making a follow-up based on the Answers given by the Minister, would that constitute—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Tell me which part of the Answer by the Minister indicated he has failed to do A, B, C, D. And you have heard that directly from the Member? Is that from the Answer?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, in this House, you guide us. But I am saying, but not absolutely—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes. So, I listened carefully to the tangent on which the Member was going before overruling him.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, then would you kindly grant him the opportunity to reframe his question there?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, he had the opportunity to reframe, but he asked a different supplementary question, which I again overruled because the question is talking about a particular period, from 2020 to 2023, but his supplementary question was on 2025.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I was trying to guide my Colleague, just signalling him what he should do so that he can live within the provisions of Order 88(7)(a). I implore you, Mr Speaker, with respect, to grant him the opportunity to reframe his follow-up.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, he can. If he wants to reframe within the ambit of the Question, I have no problem.

Mr Yeboah: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, with reference to the table, can the Hon Minister tell this House the best practice in terms of claims payment, whether or not every claim is paid within the month it is submitted, or there will be lapses in terms of months before they are paid?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us take a look at the Question. It says:

“To ask the Minister for Health to provide the claims amount for the year 2020-2023 and the types of claims for the respective years of the NHIS”.

This was the Question. So, the Minister has provided you with the details, and you are asking for monthly—

Yes, Hon Yeboah?

Mr Yeboah: Mr Speaker, thank you for the guidance, but the Minister, in answering the Question, brought the element of arrears in his Answer. I just want to know from him, with international practice, is it the case that all claims are paid in the month they are submitted? So that we know, because he mentioned arrears. So, I think that was a valid question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I do not see the Question talking about the manner of payment. He was to provide information on the claim that has been paid within the period.

Yes, Hon Kabiru Mahama, do you have a supplementary question?

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama: Yes, Mr Speaker, I do.

Mr Speaker, the Minister, in his response, on page 43, states, and I quote:

“In 2025, claims processing and payment accelerated to the point that payments were made faster than the three-month window stipulated under the NHIS Act. In the same year, a total of GHC2,688.6 million was paid to service providers, in addition to the transfer of GHC1.5 billion to the Ghana Medical Trust Fund.”

Mr Speaker, my question is, what was the total arrears as of 2020 accumulated, or payment claims accumulated till 2025, of which GHC2 billion was paid? I want to know the claims that were accumulated for that year, of which—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Question overruled. The Question relates to the period from 2020 to 2023.

Yes, Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, the Question demanded answers for claim payment between 2020 and 2023. Mr Speaker, I am fortified by the rules that require of me to ask supplementary questions based on the Answer given by the Minister. I therefore proceed to ask—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: There is a proviso that people normally forget.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Which is, Mr Speaker?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: If you have the rules book, you can take the entire House to Standing Order 89. There is a proviso, “but”.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Very well, Mr Speaker, I am happy to do that. Mr Speaker, please, you have given a guide. Let me read it aloud. Mr Speaker, Standing Order 89, Supplementary Question. 89(1), quote:

“As soon as a Question is answered, any Member beginning with the Member who asked the Question may, without notice, ask a Supplementary Question for further clarification of any matter of fact on the answer but a Supplementary Question shall not introduce a matter not included in the original question.”

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, that is why I am drawing your attention to the fact that there is a proviso.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, to the extent that the supplementary question is squarely within the ambit of the answer provided—Mr Speaker, with respect, I cannot ask a supplementary question outside of the Answer. So, Mr Speaker, if a question is asked for 2020 to 2023, and the Minister in his own Answer decides to go outside of the 2020-2023 to now give further information, any supplementary question anchored in that would be well placed within Order 89.

Mr Speaker, well, you are setting the rules—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: If you read further—I am not setting the rules—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, that is what it means.

11:21 a.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: If you read further, it says “but a Supplementary Question shall not introduce...” that is why in interpretation, you read—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, please allow me—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is why in interpretation, you read the provision as a whole.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, you are presiding and you have put a question so let me answer you. Mr Speaker, indeed you read the provision as a whole; you cannot be disjunctive. But we will also be creating problems if we say that the supplementary question, which would ordinarily depend on the Answer the Minister has given, there cannot be any supplementary question unless there is an Answer. Mr Speaker, if the Minister introduces a matter of fact in his Answer, there must be an interrogation there too. A Member of Parliament cannot be restrained merely because the supplementary question may appear to introduce a new matter. Then we cannot have a supplementary question in this Chamber.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, the rule is to guide all of us. You are introducing an issue of interpretation, so let me hear Majority Leader before you ask your supplementary question.

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I am tempted to side with the Minority

Leader’s view of the provisions of the relevant Standing Order. If a Member should ask the Minister for Health a question on the cause of malaria and the Minister in answering the question, says the cause of malaria is XYZ, it is similar to the cause of diabetes, heart attack, *et cetera*. The Minister has veered off from the specific Question but in answering has provided new facts and issues. So any Member can then follow up and say that the Minister spoke about diabetes, so they have a follow-up question on that. Whatever a Minister stands here and say, once they introduce a new fact, a Member becomes entitled to ask for further clarification regarding the fact introduced by the Minister. That is why Ministers must be careful in answering questions and focus on the specifics of the question and not veer off because once they veer off, they open themselves up to a lot of follow-up questions. The Minister may provide the Answer for the main Question but then leave room to be taken on with other matters that ought not to have been spoken about, so I do agree that if Minister answers questions and added new facts—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I beg to differ in the sense that the rules are clear and guide Questions and supplementary questions, but there is no rule that guides the kind of answers that Ministers should give. That is why this particular rule is saying that as soon as a Question is answered, any Member, beginning with the Member who asked the Question may, without notice, ask a Supplementary Question for further clarification of any matter of fact on the answer but a Supplementary Question

shall not introduce a matter not included in the original question. Therefore, though the Minister is not guided as to how to provide an Answer to the Question, this “but” is guiding you to ask the Supplementary Question within the question. So the meaning that I gathered from the use of “but” here is that it is admonishing you that a supplementary question shall not introduce a matter not included in the original question. So, the understanding here is that the fact that the Minister deviated does not mean you can ask a question on cholera and ask a supplementary question on diabetes.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, it says as soon as a Question is answered, any Member beginning with the Member who asked the Question may, without notice, ask a Supplementary Question for further clarification of any matter of fact on the Answer, but not the Question. But a Supplementary Question shall not introduce a matter not included in the original question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, “not included in the original question” and not the Answer. That is why we need to interpret the provision as a whole and take cognisance of the fact that Ministers are not guided on the kind of answers they should bring but the rules provide a guide on asking a Supplementary Question.

Mr Ayariga: Yes, I agree with you, Mr Speaker except to say that it appears to me that the rule makes provision for two issues to be dealt with. One, if you provide an answer outside the

framework of the question, you open yourself up but then also—[Laughter]

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I believe that there is no mischief here because a Supplementary Question, with the reading of the provision in whole, emanates from the answers given to a substantive Question. That is why sometimes a Member may not ask a Supplementary Question because he is satisfied with the answers given. So that is the purpose for this provision. Now the introduction of “...but a Supplementary Question shall not introduce a matter not included in the original Question” serves no purpose at all.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, it is part of the provisions and you are saying it serves no purpose?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, yes, it serves no purpose because a Supplementary Question will emanate from the answers provided. So, to the extent that the Member’s Supplementary Question finds a basis in the answer provided, I believe that you may permit him.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, if you say it serves no purpose, does it form part of the rules?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, it does.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Why would it form part of the rules yet will not serve any purpose?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Because when you ask a Supplementary Question, the basis of it—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Probably, you may ask that the rule be amended. But so long as I am concerned, once it is part of the rules, I will place interpretation on it. I will not say that it serves no purpose.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, if you may hear me—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you know that you must pass through the text to the purpose?

11:31 a.m.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Yes, of course, and I am saying that reading this provision, not just 89(1), but 89 (1)(2) and (3), that “latter-day” provision is dangling. It is a dangling modifier. It does not provide any relevance.

Now, we can only say that the supplementary question has no basis in the Answer provided. But once the Member is able to point to the fact that, as part of the answer provided and advertised, there is a basis to ask, then, Mr Speaker, I believe that you may grant him.

That is my opinion on the matter.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I beg to differ. I am looking at the text of the law.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I think you are right. If you read Order 89—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Allow him to speak his mind freely.

Yes, Hon Sulemana.

Alhaji Yusif Sulemana: Mr Speaker, I think we learn from each other, and we are allowed to speak our minds. If you ask me, what has just happened is—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, contribute to the issue of interpretation.

Alhaji Y. Sulemana: I want to finish with this. Then, I come to the interpretation. The Deputy Whip wants to speak, but the Minority Leader is asking him not to speak. That, for me, is an infringement on his rights. He should be allowed to speak. It is important to hear him.

Mr Speaker, my contribution is this. Two very important issues.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The right to speak in this House is voluntary. So, you cannot compel anybody to—

Alhaji Y. Sulemana: Hon Habib Iddrisu is a man on his own. The Minority Leader should not gag him.

Mr Speaker, I think that we are all learning. I have been here for some time now. I was one of those who always asked Questions and followed up to scrutinise and ask for accountability. When Questions are asked, we provide

information in our effort to answer them, and we veer off and bring in other matters. It makes it impossible for the person who filed the Question to ask for more information. So, yes, they are there today. We will not be there anytime soon, but there is a possibility.

So, I think that if the Minister has the information to provide, he should be given the opportunity to do so. Because at the end of the day, it amounts to accountability, and that is what this House is supposed to do.

Finally, I also want to appeal to my Brothers on the other Side. They are not many, and they have no other business except to come here. But they are only 10 in number. They should not be paid. In our case, some of us are Ministers and Deputy Ministers.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Sulemana, you are completely out of order.

Hon Members, I agree with you that when Ministers are asked Questions, they should limit themselves to the answer to the Question but my disagreement is that because the Minister erred in going outside the Question, the supplementary question must also go outside. That is why I read Standing Order 89.

Yes, your supplementary question.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Well, Mr Speaker, I am of the opinion that in this Chamber, we transact public Business and act in the national interest. Any

interpretation of our rules that results in absurdity must be avoided. I so submit that the rules are very clear: when there is a need for clarity, one must ask the question based on the Answer.

Mr Speaker, that said—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, with that said, I also beg to differ.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: No problem, Mr Speaker, you are presiding.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I take exception to the fact that my interpretation resulted in absurdity.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, do not misquote me. I have not said your—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The rules—Hear me out.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, because you said something which is wrong. I said we should avoid—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Will you observe Standing Order 124?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Which is? Mr Speaker, do not get me wrong. You are misquoting me to make a position I said we should avoid. That is my submission. I did not say you made an interpretation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Normally, the rules are clear but when the rules are interpreted, and you disagree, what you do is also clear within the law.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I did not get the impression that you had ruled, but let us proceed.

Mr Speaker, I proceed to ask the Minister, based on the second and third paragraphs of his Answer at page 43.

“Mr Speaker, the current Government is committed to restoring payment discipline and improving claims management so that annual claims expenditure is more consistently matched by payments, arrears are prevented from building up, and providers can deliver services to NHIS members without disruption.

Mr Speaker, this commitment is already being reflected in improved payment performance. In 2025, claims processing and payment accelerated to the point that payments were made faster than the three-month window stipulated under the NHIS Act.”

Based on these, Mr Speaker, I want to ask the Hon Minister whether this Answer suggests that 2025 payment claims have been paid to date.

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, as far as I know, all claims that have been submitted to the National Health Insurance Authority (NHIA) without issues have been settled. Thank you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Minister goes further to say,

“In the same year, a total of GHC2,688.6 million was paid to service providers, in addition to the transfer of GHC1.5 billion to the Ghana Medical Trust Fund.”

Mr Speaker, the Minister off record is saying that that is an error because that was where I was coming to. So can he, with your leave, correct the error so that I can properly situate my question?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Ask your question.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, very well.

The Minister claims that there is GHC2,688,600,000 as total claims paid to service providers. Is that correct? The figure.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minister.

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, the amount stated as read by the Hon Minority Leader should actually be in billions and not in millions. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Now, Mr Speaker, with that factual error having been corrected upon my prompting, can the Minister then confirm — and he uses the phrase “in the same year” — whether the total amount of GHC2.6 billion plus includes the 2025 financial year that he has made reference to, or it is only for the 2025 financial year claims? I will take it again.

In his Answer, he stated that,

“In the same year, a total of GH¢2,688.6 million was paid to service providers, in addition to the transfer of GH¢1.5 billion to the Ghana Medical Trust Fund”.

11:41 a.m.

Now my first question is, with the GH¢2.6 billion payment, the Minister says “...in the same year...”, and there is some ambiguity, so I want clarification. Is it for the payment that he made for that particular year only, or it is for the entire period up to the end of the 2025 financial year?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, it included the arrears we came to meet.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, my final question.

The Hon Minister also indicated that there was an additional GH¢1.5 billion to the Ghana Medical Trust Fund. May I know from him whether this GH¢1.5 billion covered the entire allocation for the Ghana Medical Trust Fund for the financial year 2025?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, per the 2025 National Health Insurance Formula, there was a clear allocation of GH¢1.5 billion to the MahamaCares, and that was what was released to them for the 2025 fiscal year.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, let us move to Question numbered 554, standing in the name of Hon Alexander Akwasi Acquah.

Yes?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: Mr Speaker, thank you very much. I have the permission and authority of Hon Akwasi Acquah to ask —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please do.

Current State of Healthcare Infrastructure and Plans to Improve Conditions of Health Facilities

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib on behalf of Mr Alexander Akwasi Acquah (NPP — Akim Oda): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Health the current state of healthcare infrastructure in Ghana, and what plans are in place to improve the conditions of health facilities, particularly in underserved areas?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, I thank the Hon Member for Akim Oda for the Question on the current state of healthcare infrastructure and the plans in place to improve conditions, particularly in underserved areas.

Mr Speaker, the Government remains committed to improving access to quality healthcare through stronger health infrastructure and reliable essential medical equipment across the country, with particular attention to underserved areas.

While investments over the years have expanded the network of facilities,

infrastructure gaps and maintenance backlogs remain and can affect efficiency, patient safety, and quality of service delivery. To address this in a structured manner, the Ministry has developed the Health Infrastructure Strategic Plan and the Ghana Health Infrastructure Strategy 2025–2029 to guide priority expansion, rehabilitation, and upgrading interventions, subject to available fiscal space.

In practical terms, an Equipment Retooling Programme is underway to replace obsolete and non-functional equipment nationwide. Under this programme, the dialysis machines initiative has been prioritised and is currently at the tendering stage to expand access to dialysis services and improve the management of renal conditions.

Maintenance culture is also being strengthened. Health service agencies, including the Ghana Health Service and Teaching Hospital facilities, have been directed to allocate no less than 10 per cent of their Internally Generated Funds towards maintenance and the replacement of equipment, to reduce avoidable breakdowns and preserve functionality.

In addition, urgent gaps in life-saving equipment are being addressed through targeted support to facilities with immediate needs. This includes the provision of equipment to facilities such as Asawinso Hospital and the Tamale Teaching Hospital, among others, as well as the supply of anaesthesia machines to various hospitals to stabilise

critical services while broader retooling and upgrading measures take effect.

Mr Speaker, these measures demonstrate the Government's practical commitment to improving infrastructure conditions and ensuring that health facilities are adequately equipped to deliver quality services to the people of Ghana.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary questions?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I want to find out from the Minister; he reiterated issues of maintenance, basically the maintenance culture. Has he adverted to some facilities, especially at the Korle-Bu Teaching Hospital and the Komfo Anokye Teaching Hospital, and what we are doing to ensure that we have the best in terms of maintenance?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, there is a policy directive to that effect. What we have realised in this country is that when the Government buys equipment for these health facilities, within a particular number of years, and this equipment are faulty or obsolete, they still require the Government to bring money for the maintenance of this equipment or even for their replacement. We found that this approach was not sustainable so, first, we are charging all health facilities to ring-fence money, especially generated by the same equipment, for their maintenance or replacement.

Mr Speaker, we are also inviting the private sector in what we call hospital equipment placement, or the Public–Private Partnership (PPP), where private members are invited to these health facilities, to put their equipment there, maintain the equipment themselves, and they are paid according to usage.

Mr Speaker, another approach is also that we are considering how we can separate the management of this hospital equipment from the management of the hospitals, so that we will pay attention to routine maintenance of the equipment and even replace them as and when necessary.

Mr Speaker, retooling of hospital equipment is a very important or integral part of a health facility. Without the appropriate hospital equipment, we can do very little when it comes to taking care of patients in our health facilities.

Thank you.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, one of the key features of underserved areas is the shortage of health professionals—*[Interruption]*—But he was talking about underserved areas, and I am saying that one of the key characteristics of underserved areas is the shortage of health professionals, and we are also very minded about a lot of nurses who are still sitting at home. I want to find out from the Minister—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I just want to remind you that the question is on the current state of health infrastructure.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I want to find out from the Minister that with reference to health infrastructure, is he considering moving beyond only the ten of the Agenda 111 projects that he intended to complete within the 2026 financial year?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Question is on the current state of health infrastructure. So, if the facility is not constructed, could we be talking about the current state of health infrastructure in terms of that?

11:51 p.m.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I am at a loss on whether or not a project which is a health facility with stages of construction and usage, cannot be termed as a health infrastructure. Is it the case that the Speaker is saying that an Agenda 111 Project which is about 98 per cent is not a health infrastructure—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, if you want to ask a Question about the Agenda 111 Project which is at 98 per cent, you could ask the Question and the Minister would prepare to come and answer. One thing that the rule seeks to do is to avoid the element of surprise. Yes, Hon Member?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I would like to find out from the Minister, if his Answer to the Question is part of the health infrastructure that the Minister for Finance budgeted GHC10 million towards the completion of The Agenda 111 Project?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Your Question is overruled? Yes, Hon Member?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, this one is not directly to the Question. The Deputy Minister for Lands and Natural Resources, Alhaji Yusif Sulemana made a statement that I want you to order it to be expunged. He said that we were 10 in number on our Side and we were never 10 in number. So that should be expunged. We were not 10 in number, so that part should be expunged.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: As for that one, the record will show, so do not worry about it.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, no, what would the records show? Mr Speaker, just count us; we are more than 10 Members, so it cannot be a statement of fact. It should be expunged—

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think that the record should reflect exactly what happened here. We do not know the number as at that time. According to somebody who counted, they were 10. But now, I think they are 13—*[Interruption]*—I think now they are 13 in number. I agree with him that it should be withdrawn, so that we will continue proceeding. So, it should be withdrawn.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Yes, Hon Member?

Alhaji Yusif Sulemana: Mr Speaker, thank you for this opportunity.

Mr Speaker, my good Brother, Alhaji Habib, has raised an issue that has to do with their attendance, and we do not want anybody to raise any issue on Quorum. We want Government Business to continue and I know that they are committed in ensuring that Government Business continues—*[Hear! Hear!]*—

Mr Speaker, I withdraw that statement. In fact, if they want, I will apologise and say that they are more than 10; there are 11 in number—*[Laughter]*—so, let us continue

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Prof Kingsley Nyarko?

Prof Kingsley Nyarko: Mr Speaker, thank you for indulging me.

For the record, our Friends opposite us are less than 30 in number.

Mr Speaker, I would like to find out from the Minister, if the Ministry and the Minister will be intentional in providing financial support to actualise the Ghana Health Infrastructure Strategy 2025-2029. Because in his response, he said that they will be activated when they have fiscal space. But I am asking if he would be intentional in finding resources to actualise this strategy?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, you may answer for whatever it is worth.

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, my response to this Question is that, His Excellency the President of the Republic of Ghana, Mr John Dramani Mahama has made an emphatic statement that he is

not going to abandon any ongoing or already abandoned projects. So, we have comprehensive programmes to make sure all these projects are completed.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Yeboah: I had wanted to talk to my Senior, Mr Akandoh privately. But since the National Democratic Congress (NDC) Members are 19, I want to say it here, so that they will hear it on television.

Paragraph three of his Answer reads;

“Under this programme, the dialysis machine initiative has been prioritised and is currently under the tendering stage to expand access to dialysis service and improve the management of renal conditions.”

Since, the Hon Minister, mentioned that the process is at the tendering stage, can he educate this House or give the information on whether or not the procurement method they are using is international, national competitive or single-sourced?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Question overruled. Yes, Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko, you have the floor.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, the Minister indicated in paragraph five of his Answer which said that,

“The maintenance health service agencies, including Ghana Health Service and teaching hospital facilities, have been directed to allocate not less than 10 per cent of their internally generated funds towards maintenance.”

I would like to find out from the Minister that since this directive was given, what has been the status of allocating 10 per cent? What has been the status of the hospitals and the teaching hospitals making that allocation for maintenance for the hospitals?

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minister?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, this directive is a very new one. It was issued early this year, and we are following up with implementation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to the Question numbered 555, standing in the name of Alexander Akwasi Acquah.

Plans to Address Poor Maintenance Culture and to Equip Health Facilities

Mr Alexander Akwasi Acquah (NPP — Akim Oda): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

I beg to ask the Minister for Health what plans the Ministry has to address the issue of poor maintenance culture in healthcare facilities and ensure that they are equipped to provide quality healthcare services.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, I am grateful to the Hon Member for Akim Oda for the Question on the Ministry's plans to address poor maintenance culture in health facilities and ensure that facilities are adequately equipped to deliver quality healthcare services.

The Ministry of Health recognises that sustainable healthcare infrastructure and reliable medical equipment depend on a strong maintenance culture, effective asset management, and timely replacement of obsolete equipment. In response to observed weaknesses in routine and planned preventive maintenance in some facilities, deliberate steps are being implemented. These include strengthening maintenance governance through sector-wide maintenance policies and standards, supported by an equipment policy that provides clear guidelines for servicing, upkeep, and replacement.

An asset management and maintenance system is also being implemented to improve planning, tracking, and accountability, and to shift facilities from ad hoc repairs to planned preventive maintenance.

Capacity is being strengthened through sensitisation and targeted training of facility managers on planned preventive and routine maintenance. In addition, all health service agencies, including the Ghana Health Service and Teaching Hospital facilities, have been instructed to allocate a fixed percentage of their Internally Generated Funds towards maintenance to ensure predictable financing and reduce avoidable breakdowns.

Mr Speaker, maintenance has also been strengthened through regulation and oversight. In particular, maintenance is now a key metric in assessments conducted by the Health Facilities Regulatory Agency, so that routine inspections and licensing processes take account of infrastructure condition, equipment functionality, and adherence to maintenance plans.

Mr Speaker, these measures are intended to institutionalise regular maintenance and keep facilities safe, functional, and properly equipped for quality service delivery.

12.01 p.m.

First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary question?

Mr Acquah: Mr Speaker, I have one supplementary question. Does the Ministry have any plans of outsourcing some of these maintenance jobs to other private people who could readily be available to maintain our equipment?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

Can there be an available Leader?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Majority Side must know that their Frontbench must not be empty at all. There is nobody there. It is empty.

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, the observation from the Hon Member is accurate and it is in our contemplation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to Question number 251—Hon Member, you need to get up quickly because I look around. There was nobody thereafter.

Yes, Nana Osei-Adjei?

Nana Osei-Adjei: Mr Speaker, in the Minister's Answer on 10 per cent of IGF, he said Ghana Health Service and teaching hospital facilities have been directed to allocate no less than 10 per cent of their IGF. In the next question too, he says they have been instructed to allocate a fixed percentage of their IGF. I want to find out from the Minister, what is the actual percentage?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, not less than 10 per cent.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Question numbered 251, standing in the name of Hon Mavis Kuukua Bissie. You have the floor.

Status of the Western Regional Hospital Project at Apemanim

Ms Mavis Kuukua Bissie (NDC — Ahanta West): I beg to ask the Minister

for Health, the status of the Western Regional Hospital Project at Apemanim which was awarded to Amandi Construction under the NPP Government and the measures being taken to ensure its timely completion.

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, I thank the Hon Member for Ahanta West for the Question on the status of the Western Regional Hospital project at Apemanim and the measures being taken to commence works and ensure timely completion.

Mr Speaker, the project was affected by the Domestic Debt Exchange Programme in 2022, which disrupted financing for externally funded infrastructure projects. Consequently, works stalled in 2023, and both the Apemanim project and the Effia Nkwanta redevelopment remain suspended, pending debt restructuring and the renewal of financing agreements with the relevant Export Credit Agencies.

Mr Speaker, Government is actively working to conclude the restructuring and renew the financing framework, after which the Apemanim Hospital Project will be placed back on track for completion to ease pressure on existing facilities in the Western Region.

First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary questions?

Ms Bissie: Mr Speaker, no supplementary.

First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to Question number 265, standing in the name of Hon Emmanuel Tobbin.

Mr Seth Osei-Akoto on behalf of Mr Emmanuel Tobbin (NPP — Anyaa Sowutuom): I beg to ask the Minister for Health the status of the Agenda 111 District Hospital in the Anyaa Sowutuom Constituency in the Ga Central Municipality.

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, I am grateful to the Hon Member for Anyaa Sowutuom for the Question on the current status of the Agenda 111 District Hospital project in the Anyaa Sowutuom Constituency within the Ga Central Municipality.

Mr Speaker, with respect to the completion arrangements, the Ministry of Finance, by correspondence dated 13th February, 2025, formally notified the Ministry of Health to incorporate the Agenda 111 projects into its budget proposals for 2025 and beyond, and the Ministry has accordingly captured the Agenda 111 programme in its 2025 budget. Further to this, following a handover directive from the Presidency, the Ministry has taken charge of the Agenda 111 projects.

Following the handover, the Ministry engaged the management team from AESL to undertake a special audit assignment, and the report has been submitted. In due course, the Ministry will finalise a strategic implementation plan for Agenda 111 and engage the Ministry of Finance for the necessary

guidance and support towards a dedicated budgetary allocation. The Ministry will also explore complementary financing options, including support from private partners who may be interested in assisting to complete this important project.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry remains committed to working closely with all stakeholders to ensure the timely and successful delivery of the district hospital for the people of Anyaa Sowutuom and the wider Ga Central Municipality.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary questions?

Mr Osei-Akoto: Mr Speaker, thank you. I rest my case.

First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Question time is ended. On your behalf, I sincerely thank the Minister for Health for attending upon the House to respond to scheduled Questions. You are accordingly discharged.

Hon Members, by the agreement of the House, we are moving to Statements. The first Statement is by the Young Parliamentarians Forum. You have the floor.

Hon Members, if they are not here, I will direct that the Statement be published in the *Hansard*.

Yes, Hon Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I believe that the next in line is by the Minority Chief Whip. So, we will take it in that order.

First Deputy Speaker: Well, I will do it in the order that it appears in the *Order Paper*. So, I will direct that the Statement numbered 9(a) be published in the *Hansard*.

STATEMENTS

Digital Sexual Exploitation and the Urgent Need for Online Intervention

Mr Speaker, I rise on behalf of the Young Parliamentarians Forum to address a matter of urgent national concern. In recent days, our country has been confronted with disturbing reports and videos involving the sexual exploitation and non-consensual recording of young Ghanaian women. These acts allegedly recorded and circulated without the consent of the women involved, constitute a grave violation of their dignity, privacy and fundamental human rights.

Mr Speaker, the non-consensual recording and distribution of intimate images is not a trivial matter. It is not entertainment. It is a criminal offence. It is digital sexual abuse and it must be treated with the seriousness it deserves. Equally concerning is the continued circulation of these videos across social media platforms and messaging channels. Every forward, every repost, every upload compounds the trauma of the victims. We must be clear that those who continue to share such content are aiding its violation.

Mr Speaker, preliminary engagements available to us indicate that many of the affected young women are economically vulnerable. There are indications that a number of them work within the retail sector, including some large retail shops operating in Ghana. This highlights a troubling intersection between economic vulnerability and sexual exploitation. When young women are trapped in precarious employment and financial insecurity, they become easy targets for manipulation and abuse.

This is therefore not only a criminal justice issue. It is a social protection, labour and digital governance issue. On behalf of the Young Parliamentarians Forum, we make the following urgent calls:

First, we call on the Ghana Police Service and relevant security agencies to intensify efforts to secure the arrest and prosecution of the perpetrator, including through cross border cooperation where necessary.

Again, we call for a thorough investigation into any networks or individuals who may have facilitated this exploitation and urge the appropriate authorities to stem the spread of these videos online.

Mr Speaker, the digital space must not become a market place for humiliation and abuse. We call for the provision of confidential psychosocial support and legal assistance to the victims, ensuring their privacy and dignity are protected at every stage.

Mr Speaker, Ghana must send a strong signal that we will not tolerate digital sexual exploitation. Our young women deserve safety, dignity and opportunity, not exploitation.

The Young Parliamentarians Forum stands firmly with the victims. We demand accountability and we call on all institutions of state to act swiftly and decisively.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

[Published by Order of Mr Speaker]

First Deputy Speaker: Let us now take 9(b), it stands in the name of Hon Frank Annoh-Dompreh, Member of Parliament for Nsawam/Adoagyiri. You have the floor.

Legislation on Ecocide in Ghana

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh (NPP — Nsawam/Adoagyiri): Mr Speaker, thank you. Mr Speaker, I rise today with a profound sense of urgency and responsibility to speak on a matter that transcends partisan politics, economic growth and short-term development agenda.

12:11 p.m.

I speak to the need for legislative action against ecocide — the mass destruction of ecosystems — and for Ghana to align itself with a growing global movement to make environmental devastation a punishable crime, both domestically and internationally.

Mr Speaker, Ecocide, as defined by an independent expert panel convened by Stop Ecocide International refers to:

“Unlawful or wanton act of committed with knowledge that there is a substantial likelihood of severe and either widespread or long-term damage to the environment”.

This is not abstract rhetoric: it is a legal concept with measurable criteria — damage that is severe, widespread, or long-term. It goes far beyond regulatory fines or administrative sanctions. It is about criminal accountability for decisions and actions that destroy the very foundation of life and livelihood.

Mr Speaker, the current legal framework in international law, notably the Rome Statute of International Criminal Court, lists genocide, crimes against humanity, war crimes, and aggression. Ecocide is not yet to recognise as a standalone international crime during peacetime, even though environmental destruction today causes consequences on par with the grievous human rights abuses.

Mr Speaker, this absence in international law creates a legal vacuum: corporations, state actors, and individuals can commit ecological destruction — deforestation, industrial pollution, oil spills, and climate amplifying activities — with limited criminal liability. This is not just a theoretical concern. The Nigerian Niger Delta, for example, has suffered over 7,000 oil spills from 1970 to 2000,

devastating water, soil, and human health, and with full environmental restoration estimated to take decades. Such destruction is a paradigmatic of ecocide.

Globally, however, momentum is building to fill this void. At least 11 countries have already incorporated ecocide into their domestic law, including Armenia, Belarus, Kazakhstan, Russia, Ukraine, Moldova, Georgia, Ecuador, Chile, France, and Belgium. In 2023, Belgium became the first European Union country to criminalise ecocide as part of its penal code revisions, demonstrating a political will to hold those who cause severe ecological harm to account. Across the world, Brazil, Mexico, the Netherlands, Italy, Argentina, French Polynesia, India, Democratic Republic of Congo, and Peru, who are advancing legislative proposals aim at similar goals.

Mr Speaker, this is not merely environmental law – It is justice law. Recognising ecocide as a crime embeds a moral framework into legal systems. As noted by legal scholars and advocates, criminalisation signals a societal consensus that destroying ecosystems is morally and legally unacceptable, similar to how criminal law treats thefts or harm to persons.

In Africa, the Democratic Republic of Congo publicly endorsed ecocide as an international crime at a 2024 UN Biodiversity Conference, joining the cause from the Pacific states like Fiji, Vanuatu, and Samoa to strengthen the environmental protection through criminal law. Why should Ghana act now?

- i. **Ecological Boundary Crossing:** As a country affected by deforestation, illegal mining (*galamsey*), and water pollution, Ghana's ecosystem is under severe stress. Recent reports indicate that up to 60 per cent of our water bodies have suffered pollution due to illegal mining, a form of uncontrolled environmental degradation that threatens health, agriculture, and future prosperity.
- ii. **Moral Responsibility:** Environmental stability is foundational to food security, human health, and sustainable economic development. The consequences of ecological damage are anti-generational – they affect our children, their livelihoods, and their right to a healthy environment. Criminalising ecocide affirms our collective duty of care towards our nature and future generations.
- iii. **International Leadership:** By legislating ecocide as a crime, Ghana can position itself as a leader in environmental justice in Africa – much like the Democratic Republic of the Congo and Belgium on their respective continent – showing that environmental protection is inseparable from human rights, climate justice, and sustainable development.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, we must pass a Domestic Ecocide Law: Introduce a stand-alone legal provision defining

and criminalising ecocide with clear thresholds for severity, duration, and impact, model on the stop-ecocide international definition.

Align with International Law: Advocate at the Assembly of States, Parties of the International Criminal Court to include ecocide as the fifth international crime, thereby enabling prosecution of the most severe environmental harms globally. Ghana has an opportunity to be a regional and continental leader championing ecocide law to protect not only Ghana, but at the African Environmental Ministerial Conference on Environment (AEMCEN) and at the African Union.

Strengthen Enforcement Mechanisms: Empower Ghana's environmental protection agencies and judiciary with investigative authority, evidence standards, and prosecutorial capacity to ensure accountability.

Penal Sanctions and Remedies: Ensure penalties are proportionate and deterrent, including custodian sentences as well as financial penalties for individuals and corporations and mandatory environmental restoration orders.

Mr Speaker, protecting our ecosystems is not an optional policy. It is a fundamental commitment to future generations, to human dignity, and to the harmony between economic development and environmental stewardship. Let us give meaning to that commitment by making ecocide a crime and Ghanaian

law by supporting its recognition under international law.

I recommend the Government in proposing the creation of a national crime of Ecocide as part of the proposal made by the Constitutional Review Committee (Transforming Ghana: From electoral democracy to developmental democracy – Chapter 111, para, 3.18) and urge a swift progression in the creation of national ecocide legislation to protect our economy now and into the future.

Mr Speaker, I thank you, and I am grateful.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

Hon Members, any guidance to the number of comments that we will take on each Statement? We have about 12 Statements for today.

Mr Dafeamekpor: I am trying to reach an agreement with my Brother. That is his Statement. So, given the number of Statements we have, we want to agree that we take one each and the Leadership. That makes it four. It is such a major Statement, I agree. But if we take four contributors each, then we can—Mr Speaker, we have a lot of Statements to cover.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Statements are about 12.

Very well. If that is the agreement of the House, I will then open the floor.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I am sorry. It is not an agreement of the House. It is a recommendation from him.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. What do you say to it?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, because I am involved, I do not want to hazard any guess. But clearly, if you see Hon Colleagues who are—I think two should be alright. That is my humble view.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, that is what he is saying. But the two each should include Leadership. So, four comment on one Statement.

Yes, in order of seniority, I will give the floor to Hon Charles Agbeve.

Mr Charles Agbeve (NDC — Agotime-Ziope): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for recognising my seniority.

12:21 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I first of all want to commend the maker of the Statement. Ever since I joined Parliament, he has been very consistent in making Statements on the environment. In fact, he has been consistent, persistent and passionate about Statements on the environment.

Ecocide is definitely a crime. By its own definition, mass destruction of the ecosystem. Unfortunately, only 11 countries have passed a domestic law on ecocide, and in Africa, only one, the

Democratic Republic of Congo. It even tells us that the world or the countries in the world are not taking issues of the environment seriously. Criminalising ecocide is critical. We have laws already that punishes people who infringe on the ecosystem or the environment, but I think making a law on ecocide will further strengthen and deter people from destroying the ecosystem or the environment.

Mr Speaker, ecocide as researched and well written by the maker of the Statement helps us to criminalise destruction of the environment. In doing so, we will position Ghana with Democratic Republic of Congo in Africa as the country's leading charge. It is important for me because we have challenges in Ghana such as sand wining, plastic waste, *galamsey*, and pollution of water bodies. It is important for us to show commitment and seriousness by passing this law criminalising ecocide. It is important for us to work towards protecting nature and the future generations of this country.

I also support the call to make ecocide the fifth international crime. That way, then we can make sure that countries will comply with very important legislations concerning ecocide. Mr Speaker, with these few words, I want to thank the maker of the Statement and encourage him to continue the good work he is doing on the environment.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us have in mind that the comment should not exceed five minutes. Yes, Dr Kabiru?

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama (NPP — Walewale): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. Let me also join in commending the Minority Chief Whip for his consistency on this subject matter. His attitude towards the environment is something that we must all emulate as Members of Parliament (MP), especially when environmental issues are at the heart of even contemporary development issues.

Mr Speaker, the maker of the Statement brings our attention to a very major issue, ecocide. We know as a fact that deliberate, wanton and mass destruction of human lives constitutes a crime internationally. If human life is not to be distinguished, I think plant and animal lives are equally important. To the extent that persons would deliberately or negligently destroy the lives of animals and the lives of plants, it is something that we need to look at as a country.

Despite the fact that we have so many environmental laws like the Ramsar Convention which Ghana has ratified and we have six Ramsar sites currently, those sites are endangered. This is despite the strict liability of these particular offences associated with the destruction of natural and biological lives. So, Mr Speaker, the time for us to give much more attention to issues of ecocide is now. The Statement is timely.

Mr Speaker, we are making this Statement at a time that climate change is at the front burner of global issues. At the heart of ecocide, or at the heart of the destruction we cause to plants and

animals, is the issue of global warming and climate change. No country or state is isolated from the reeling effect of climate change. So, we need to embrace this.

The moral imperativeness and necessity of this particular legislation have been highlighted by the maker of the Statement. I want to add to the fact that flooding is much more common in our jurisdiction because of issues of destruction to plants and animal lives. We have issues of emergence of new diseases. We also have issues about migratory birds. Recently, I raised an issue about the fact that migratory birds are destroying farm fields in the north. All these are attendant effects of climate change and destruction to plants and animal lives.

I want to join the maker of the Statement to call on Ghana, and this Parliament to put at the heart of our deliberation and legislation issues about environment and the need to protect the environment, especially criminalising issues of deliberate destruction of plants and animals.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib (NPP — Weija/Gbawe): Mr Speaker, I thank you for this opportunity. Let me most importantly, eulogise the maker of the Statement against the backdrop that he has been more than persistent in dealing with issues of the environment. In fact, this morning I have had to personally engage him to further recommend to him to do a Doctor of Philosophy (PhD) in Environmental Law, because he is well-versed in environmental matters. That is

why it is critical for him to go beyond what he has today.

Mr Speaker, he brings to the fore ecocide. It talks about the killing of the natural environment; that is the literal definition. The natural environment is on a large scale of destruction. The massive destruction of our environment needs each and everyone's attention. The destruction emanates from human activities, one of which is *galamsey*, illegal mining.

I read a piece recently about how the Bui Dam is at the verge of destruction because of illegal mining. I have been more worried about the fact that people who hitherto were prosecutors and persecutors of *galamsey* have all gone quiet, when the situation has actually even gone beyond the prevalence level as it then was.

Mr Speaker, another which is critical, and is in fact *pari passu* is deforestation. Anybody who has to go into illegal mining will end up falling trees. When the trees are all removed, the green belt becomes devastated. In environments that we would have said to ourselves that because Accra is busy and hot, we want to drive out, go somewhere and have some quiet relaxation, we are unable to do so. Why? Because all the trees are being pulled down just because we want to make money to the neglect of very essential commodities that no human being can ever manufacture, which is air.

Mr Speaker, today, when we are talking about pollution, our lifestyles,

almost everybody drinks bottled water or water in plastic bags. People go and all they afford is sachet water or bottled water. When they are done drinking, the indiscriminate disposal of these is creating wanton filth and squalor. If care is not taken—we can check. In my constituency, for instance, any time it rains, there is a problem. Why? Because the drains are choked. All manner of de-silting and whatever has not brought any solution to these problems. People are building in waterways and nobody is able to do anything. The powers that be, respectfully, have even gone to sleep because either they are beneficiaries or they are associates.

12:31 p.m.

Mr Speaker, this Statement is critical because in recent times in the United States of America (U.S.A.), they could not even tell the inches of snow that was going to fall. When it started snowing, people could not tell whether they were going to have 22 inches of snow. These are a result of the way we handle ourselves, our human activities, and how we are damaging the ecosystem. Mr Speaker, in Ghana, the major issue, which I am very sure you bear with me on that and agree with me, is *galamsey*.

Mr Speaker, let the powers that be take a serious look at it. As the hard-working Minority Chief Whip said, there is a critical need for us to look at making laws to ensure that our environment is protected and to enforce the laws. Because, Mr Speaker, most of the laws exist. We have either refused to ensure that those laws work, or some people are

beneficiaries of non-enforcement of these laws, and therefore, they have gone to sleep, and we are suffering. We should think about the generation—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: They are keeping the five minutes automatically.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I am alright. I was hoping Leadership would be given more time, but if the time is taken, then it is fine. I want to take this opportunity to thank you once again.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Majority Leadership?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I yield to Dr Winsum Anabah?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Dr Anabah, you have five minutes.

Dr Thomas Winsum Anabah (NDC — Garu): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for allowing me to comment on this important Statement ably made by the Chief Whip of the Minority Side. I will join everybody to at least commend him for his consistency when it comes to our environment. Yes, ecocide is detrimental to us. We have heard of the definition, and we are all alarmed. It is to protect the current and future generations. If we listen to comments by other Hon Members, we are all speaking about how we are depleting the forest, which is far away. We are talking about the contamination of our water bodies, which is dangerous to our health.

As a health worker, I have looked around our big cities, and I have seen that

besides complaining about the forest being depleted our waters being contaminated, within our own environment that we have created to live in our big cities, we are practicing ecocide. We have laws in our district assemblies to prevent that from taking place, but we are failing to implement laws that will prevent us from being polluted and devolve diseases that would harm us and lead to extinction.

I want to talk about the work of the assemblies and the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA), and how to ensure that our cities are not turned into what we call methane production industries. If we look at Ghana, in all our big cities, we are gradually practicing ecocide. Rubber bags are being thrown everywhere. We go to the field site where they dump rubbish, and it is stacked with rubber. Even in farms, rubber or polythene is everywhere, preventing the ground from re-exchanging gases. We are emitting more methane in our big cities simply because we are not implementing environmental laws, and we are not executing what we are supposed to do to prevent this from happening.

So, I would say that there is low-hanging fruit. Not only is the forest being depleted, but the water is also being contaminated. In the cities where we have wetlands, we have encroached on all of them. The few forest reserves we have inside the cities to provide oxygen and pure air for us to breathe are being cut down and replaced with mansions, encroaching on them. The wetlands, which are supposed to host different

species living harmoniously with us, are being destroyed. Now, what we see in our big cities is the production of methane, which is very detrimental to our health, simply because no one is punishing the offenders. The laws are not working.

So even if we sign up to this law, as Singapore is doing, one cannot chew gum or hold a rubber bag. Just like Rwanda is doing, one cannot have a polythene bag simply because they know the devastating effects of throwing garbage everywhere. If we want to implement it in Ghana, it will be a problem. This is where I think the low-hanging fruit must be handled first. Then we can polish up this international fever that is going around in 11 countries, that ecocide should be a crime against humanity, and that it should be punishable according international laws. If this is actually realised, and the whole world accepts that ecocide is punishable by law, I think even wars in the world will change the methods of fighting our wars.

We see today that oil refineries are being blown up, which is causing chemicals to be released all around the world. We have seen how water plants in countries like Iran and Israel are being blown up, which is destroying ecosystems. I really support the call by the Leader that we should make ecocides a crime against humanity, so that wars fought around the world, no one will attempt to blast an oil refinery, because today Iran and Israel are suffering the consequences. I am not only talking for Ghana, but we have to be patriotic, and

we have to be human beings, because that alone is causing fumes across, and people will start developing diseases as a result of those chemical reactions that are taking place.

To this end, I commend the maker of the Statement and call for Ghana to also consider laws against ecocide for us to establish to prevent the destruction of the small ecosystem that we have.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That is the end of comments to that Statement ably made by the Minority Chief Whip. We will now move to the Statement numbered (c), standing in the name of Hon Dr Abed-Nego Lamangin Bandim. You have the floor.

Data Protection Week

Dr Abed-Nego A. Lamangin Bandim (NDC — Bunkpurugu): Mr Speaker, I thank you for the privilege to deliver this vital Statement in commemoration of Data Protection Week, which was last week, of which Mr Speaker, you were invited to partake, and the Second Deputy Speaker ably represented you and made a Statement on your behalf.

Mr Speaker, this is a pivotal occasion. It is dedicated to elevating national awareness, advancing fundamental policy rights, and rigorously strengthening institutional compliance. In an era where digital information drives sovereign governance and economic development, our responsibility is clear.

Safeguarding the personal data of our citizens has never been more urgent.

This House is the ultimate embodiment of democratic accountability. We recognise that the trust reposed in us by the Ghanaian citizens extends beyond legislation and oversight. It demands the absolute, uncompromising protection of their digital identity. In furtherance of this mandate, the Data Protection Commission, alongside the Ghana Association of Privacy Professionals, has adopted a compelling theme, which is: *“Your Data, Your Identity, Building Trust in Ghana’s Digital Future”*. This will anchor a comprehensive month-long series of national celebrations.

Mr Speaker, this initiative reaffirms our collective commitment to the Data Protection Act of 2012, (Act 843). The principles of (Act 843) are unequivocal. Personal data must be processed lawfully, fairly, and transparently. It must be collected exclusively for specific, legitimate purposes. It must remain accurate, secure, and retained strictly within statutory limits. Compliance is not merely a bureaucratic duty. It is a moral imperative. It underscores our profound respect for the digital autonomy and freedoms of every Ghanaian.

12:41 p.m.

We must acknowledge a hard truth about our interconnected digital ecosystem. Catastrophic data breaches are no longer just technical failures. The most severe vulnerabilities are human and behavioral. They stem from weak

cybersecurity practices, sophisticated phishing attacks, and the careless handling of official information. They also arise from exposing personal data on platforms like *Facebook*, *X*, *TikTok*, and *WhatsApp*. These platforms are invaluable for public engagement. Yet, they remain highly porous channels. Sensitive information can be unintentionally disclosed, algorithmically manipulated, or maliciously exploited.

The sophistication of cyber threats is escalating. Synthetic identity theft, digital impersonation, and unauthorised data harvesting demand uncompromising vigilance from all of us. The relentless work of our regulatory bodies highlights an absolute necessity: we need continuous education, responsible digital conduct, and strict adherence to security protocols. Data protection is not a technological dilemma we can simply outsource to IT departments. It is a fundamental human responsibility. It requires discipline and accountability at every echelon of institutional activity.

Mr Speaker, the late Dr Kofi Annan profoundly observed:

“Knowledge is power. Information is liberating. Education is the premise of progress, in every society, in every family”.

This timeless wisdom reminds us of a critical balance. The digital flow of information empowers our institutions and our citizens. But it must be managed with utmost responsibility. We must ensure its power serves the public good, rather than undermining our national security or compromising individual privacy.

Mr Speaker, Parliament handles vast quantities of highly sensitive information daily. We process restricted administrative records, citizen petitions, confidential committee documentation, and witness testimonies. The very nature of our work demands the highest echelons of data privacy protection. It is incumbent upon us to guarantee our data architectures are fortified. We must protect them against unauthorised access, misuse, or catastrophic loss. Strengthening our internal systems is essential for legal compliance. More importantly, it is vital for preserving unwavering public confidence in the integrity of this House.

In October 2025, the Select Committee on Information and Communications conducted a comprehensive working visit to the Data Protection Commission. The Committee was thoroughly briefed on the Commission's achievements, its ongoing projects, and its pressing operational challenges. We witnessed firsthand the hurdles they face in policing our digital economy. In response, we pledged our mutual, bipartisan support to their national campaign on data protection.

Mr Speaker, the Data Protection Commission has issued a formal declaration. 2026 marks the definitive beginning of a full-scale, punitive enforcement drive. The era of regulatory leniency is unequivocally over. Parliament has demonstrated exemplary leadership in the face of this paradigm shift. We have formally appointed a Data Protection Supervisor. We remain resolute in upholding the fundamental tenets of privacy across all our operations.

The Commission is rapidly scaling up punitive measures against non-compliance. Under section 56 of the Act, these include severe fines and potential imprisonment. Therefore, I strongly urge my esteemed colleagues who engage in private enterprise outside this House: ensure your organisations are strictly compliant. All businesses in Ghana must adhere to Act 843. They must register immediately with the Data Protection Commission.

Throughout this month, a diverse array of activities will be undertaken nationwide to sensitise citizens on data protection. Here in Parliament, Hon Members, Staff, and stakeholders will actively participate. These engagements will deepen our technical understanding. They will reinforce administrative accountability. Above all, they will cultivate a resilient culture of privacy consciousness across all facets of parliamentary operations.

Mr Speaker, I conclude with a charge to all Hon Members and staff of Parliament. Actively engage in the activities planned for this critical initiative. Integrate core data protection principles into your daily workflows. Let us unequivocally demonstrate that the Parliament of Ghana leads by example. We must safeguard the personal information of our constituents. We must uphold the highest standards of confidentiality, integrity, and responsibility in all that we do.

Mr Speaker, I thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Patrick Yaw Boamah?

Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah (NPP — Okaikwei Central): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make some comments on the Statement ably made by my Colleague from Bunkpurugu.

Mr Speaker, Data Protection Act, 2012 (Act 843) was passed in 2012, and I think it is about time that, with the developments in the world and the coming into force of social media which has taken over the traditional media space, it underwent some reforms and to bring the Act in conformity with the global trend.

Mr Speaker, data has been collected from us by the National Health Insurance Authority, the Driver and Vehicle Licencing Authority, National Identification Authority, the National Communications Authority, Birth and Death Registry, and other agencies of state. Data, we say, is gold, and if you read section 96 of the Act, the definition of data has been expanded, and with your kind permission, Mr Speaker, I would read just a couple for us to appreciate what we are talking about. I am reading from the section on Interpretation,

“Data means information which:

- a. is processed by means of equipment operating automatically in response to instructions given for that purpose;
- b. is recorded with the intention that it should be processed by means of such equipment...”.

Mr Speaker, there are sanctions regimes attached to the Act, which also enjoins the Minister for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovations to come to the House with some regulations to see to the implementation of this Act. Anyone who violates the use of someone’s data or without going through the right processes is required to pay about GHC60,000 or face a sentence of not less than 10 years or both.

Mr Speaker, there are legislations and laws that govern data protection. But in our country, you realise that people just abuse people’s data, use them anyhow without any sanctions or enforcement. And that requires the law enforcement agents to be trained professionally, because you have data of kids, Members of Parliament, chiefs and very prominent people and other members of society being used and abused for financial purposes without recourse to the enabling Act. It is a call in the right direction by the maker of the Statement for us to appreciate the need for data protection and also enforce the cybersecurity laws of this country to protect our image and our kids going forward.

I thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Prof Hamza Adam?

Prof Hamza Adam (NDC — Kumbungu): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I am enjoying Leadership here as available Leader. Let me commend the maker of the Statement for bringing to

fore a very important subject matter which has to do with data protection.

Mr Speaker, we all know that data is a very critical need for the development of our country. It is important for planning; it is important for economic development; it is important for growth. So, it becomes very important that we cannot do without data.

Unfortunately, Mr Speaker, technology today has made data to be very vulnerable to destruction. A lot of people now can because of technology infiltrate into people's data, so, Mr Speaker, you and I remain naked because of the technology we have today.

12:51 p.m.

And if we do not take steps to ensure that we protect data, no one is safe. If we watch the war that is happening in the Middle East, we would see that it is because of the data countries have of other countries, that is why they are able to set and target them from 2,000 miles away. They sit in their room and target somebody and because of the data, the fellow has been able to infiltrate and track. So, it is important that we pay attention to data.

Mr Speaker, in this country, a lot of people do not have understanding of how it works and so for that matter, we see people just giving themselves out and making it easy for people to go through their data. And so, in recent times we find the very bad side of people's bodies being leaked in the social media. It is because of the fact that they do not

understand how it works. So, I think that we need to do a lot of sensitisation. Days like this, it is important we take advantage and sensitise people to understand how data works today so that when they are holding their phone, they know how to manage their data. Even those who are supposed to collect data know what they are supposed to be doing, because if one is tasked to gather data, the person is supposed to ensure that they uphold to truthfulness, confidentiality and ensure that they protect the identity of the people whose data they have collected. People do not know this so if we take steps to ensure that we sensitise the public on days like this for people to understand the need to protect data, I think that will be helpful,

Mr Speaker, to wrap up, the laws we have in this country have adequately addressed that of data protection. We have enough laws. Some of them have been mentioned by my senior Colleague over there. He has enumerated a number of laws, but how to enforce this is the problem. So, I want to strongly recommend that those who are responsible in enforcing, deal with people who are found to breach these regulations are properly handled and I am sure it will serve as a deterrent to those who probably have the intention of going into that. With these few words, I thank you for the opportunity, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Second Deputy Minority Whip?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I yield to Hon Dr Kabiru Mahama.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Dr Kabiru Mahama, you have the floor; five minutes.

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama (NPP — Walewale): Mr Speaker, I would want to commend the Chairperson of my Committee for that Statement and also let me add that, we participated in the Data Protection Conference and the presentation and discussion brought to the fore, the need for us to look at the Data Protection Act, 2012 (Act 843), which Hon Patrick Boamah has alluded to, was one of the cardinal outcomes of that particular conference, the need for us to review, re-examine the current legislative framework guiding the protection of data.

Mr Speaker, since 2012, and following the enactment of the Data Protection Act, 2012 (Act 843), Parliament has been consistent in every single legislation we passed in this particular House, reflect adequately the need for data protection and I would want to commend the House of Parliament for that consistency, that we made the law and in fidelity to that law, and in being consistent with the dictates of that law, we provide for every single subsequent law we are making in this House, the need for adequate safeguards.

Mr Speaker, Act 843 provides for protection by any person or institution that is responsible for the collection and processing of data to provide some safeguards and that is why within the Act, there are requirements for data controllers to be registered with the Data Protection Commission. Mr Speaker,

this again, I want to note that Parliament is one of the few institutions that have adequately regularised and made same the registration of our data system, by making sure that as a data controller, we register with the Data Protection Commission. The issues about data protection are so serious. They are serious because every now and then we go to social media, and see the display without any sense of hiding the identity of people, valuable and vital information of persons, people splash this information of individuals, including politicians, in the public space. I think this is not what the law actually envisioned. The law actually wanted to protect us against free flow of personal information in a manner that is not prescribed by law and to see people still in the habit of exploiting and mining personal data of persons and putting same in the media or putting same in public spaces without the requirement of the law, is something that we need to look at seriously. The problem is that almost every single institution in Ghana is actually processing or collecting data in one way or the other. A data of one sort or another is going to be processed or collected even if they are data of one's employees, they still constitute part of the data of the person and I think that if we do not do something about this, a time will come that people will not feel safe about providing their data to institutions or persons responsible for the collection of this data.

Mr Speaker, the last thing I want to draw your attention to on this particular subject is the need for us, which has actually been of a flop that contingent to

this is also the right of the person, to know that our information is actually safe. Mr Speaker, with these few words, I would like to thank you very much for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have come to an end of that vital Statement on data protection. Indulge me to acknowledge the presence of Dr Arnold Kavaarpuo. He is the Acting Executive Director of Data Protection Agency. We have Abigail Yeboah, Head of Administration, Daniel Amano, Human Resource Manager, Kweku Adjei Larbi, Head of Accounts and staff of Data Protection Agency. On your behalf, I welcome them to Parliament of Ghana and urge them to have a fruitful visit to Parliament.

[Staff of the Data Protection Agency were acknowledged]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We then move to the next Statement standing in the name of Hon Felicia Adjei, Member of Parliament for Kintampo South. You have the floor.

Proportional Representation and its Role in Promoting Gender Equity in Governance

Ms Felicia Adjei (NDC — Kintampo South): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to make a Statement on a vital issue at the heart of our democracy.

Around the world, many successful democracies use proportional representation as a fairer way to convert

votes into seats and various stakeholders have been examining gender equity and seeking ways to build a better, more inclusive system in which every citizen's voice is valued.

Under this system, if a political party wins 30 per cent of the national votes, it receives about 30 per cent of the seats in Parliament. This ensures that every vote counts and that even smaller parties and minority groups are represented.

Countries such as South Africa, Namibia, Rwanda and Senegal have adopted Proportional Representation to strengthen democracy and inclusion.

Mr Speaker, Proportional Representation fosters gender inclusion.

1:01 p.m.

In Rwanda, for instance, the proportional system has allowed women to hold over 60 per cent of parliamentary seats, making it one of the most gender-balanced legislatures in the world. Ghana currently uses the first-past-the-post system, where the candidates with the most votes in their constituencies win. While simple, it often leaves many votes uncounted and reduces opportunities for women and minority groups. As a result, our Parliament does not fully reflect the diversity of our population.

Mr Speaker, the Affirmative Action (Gender Equity) Act 2024 (Act 1121) was a bold step towards encouraging women's participation. However, laws alone cannot achieve equity if the electoral system does not support

inclusion. One proven approach is the use of gender-balance, or the “Zebra” list, which requires parties to alternate between the male and female candidates when seats are allocated. This guarantees fairness by design, not by chance.

Mr Speaker, Ghana could adopt a hybrid model such as those in Germany and New Zealand, where some Members are elected from constituencies and others from parties, less based on the population of the national vote. This preserves a local representation while enhancing fairness and inclusivity.

Mr Speaker, gender equity is both justice and good governance. The Affirmative Action Act has laid a strong foundation. Proportional representation with gender-balanced lists could build upon it to create a truly inclusive and representative Parliament.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, that was a Statement made by Hon Felicia Adjei on gender equity in governance. The floor is now open for comments.

Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor.

Ms Jean-Marie Formadi (NDC — Biakoye): Mr Speaker, thank you very much. I commend the maker of this Statement highly for this Statement concerning gender and representation.

Mr Speaker, when we look at the global percentage of gender

representation in Parliament, we have just about 26.1 per cent. When it comes to Ghana, we have about 14 per cent of women representation in Parliament, which is not encouraging. So, I think it is high time our political parties make efforts not to just say they need women representation in Parliament, but ensure some political and party enforcement of the representation of women. We would be very happy as women if our seats are protected by political parties making an effort to ensure that, at least for the first or second term in Parliament, nobody should contest the seat. That would be a form of encouragement, and it would be guided by maybe our activities in Parliament.

By so doing, more women would be encouraged to work harder in Parliament because they know that if they do not perform well, maybe they will not be given that opportunity of nobody contesting them. I think that would encourage a lot of women to be more courageous in contesting the elections.

Mr Speaker, this is a time for women to take up leadership positions. The time is right for us to rise to the occasion to take political positions, not only in Parliament, but in all other aspects of leadership. Yes, in Ghana, we have a woman as a Vice President, which is a step in the right direction. And we know that many other positions are there, but it is the percentage that is lacking. So, I will use this medium to encourage our women to try to take up positions. We should not just be relaxed, feel reluctant or intimidated. Most women feel intimidated to hold this position because

men actually intimidate us sometimes. It is true; the men intimidate us sometimes. We are pleading with them to give us the space to operate and by so doing, a lot of people will be encouraged.

Mr Speaker, I will use myself as an example. Coming into politics was not an easy thing because of the kind of harsh words that men use against women in politics, especially, which is something that will not motivate someone to even try to contest. So, yes, it goes without saying that politics is a dirty game, but I do not think we need dirty people to do politics. So, we need people who can do the work, not dirty people, no. I hate to hear that politics is a dirty game. It should not be a dirty game. As I said earlier, we need clean and neat people to do the work.

So, the words that they use against us as women because we want to do politics, we are pleading, should not be because of politics. Someone used some words that I would not like to repeat here right now. So, we are pleading. Let us do the right things, support ourselves as women. We should hold each other's hands and rise to the position that we are expected to be.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Bench.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib (NPP — Weija/Gbawe): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for this opportunity and let me commend highly, the maker of this Statement.

Mr Speaker, coincidentally, yesterday was also International Women's Day. So, I would also take this opportunity to wish every woman who is in this hallowed Chamber, who is whether a legal practitioner, a media practitioner, a politician, a mother, a queen mother, a sister, or a wife, a Happy International Women's Day.

Mr Speaker, I have largely been nurtured and supported by my grandmother, who is no more. I have always found myself to understand that women have always been extremely supportive and hardworking. Anytime they intend to do something, they have always had the capacity to undertake every step they commit to. Unless or until they are not willing to do so.

But when we are talking about issues of gender, there is also the need for them to understand that times have changed. There is progress in this world. The way and manner we used to think about things is not the same. We have gone to Beijing and other places with a lot of understanding that what the man can do, the woman can do better. In fact, sometimes they say the best.

1:41 p.m.

So, there should always be the platform for equality. There should also be the platform for equity. In every step, women are largely ahead in how they even manage their homes.

Mr Speaker, when you have a wife, you are so sure that you can go home peacefully to, then you are comfortable

as a man in performing other very important functions that are not just assigned to you but are your responsibilities. Including even coming to this Chamber to make laws and including contesting elections.

So, Mr Speaker, the conversation should be automatic. Women should be given the opportunity, for instance, to contest because they are women. I think we are going beyond that. They need to work for it and they are working for it. They need to compete and win, and they are competing and winning. There are women who have beaten men in competitions. There are women who, just like she rightly said, we have the Vice President who is a woman. So, we must not come to the table and act like, with all deference, women are not in the position to do better. They should be supported: they should be funded if need be and they should not be given all manner of ill names that would actually discourage them.

The Maker of the Statement is doing better. She has gone and she has come and any other woman who has the capacity to do better can also be the President of the Republic. So, all we can do is rather to encourage you, pray with you, advise you, support you, and compete because we are largely equals and there is nobody bigger in these shoes.

So, let me once again congratulate all the women, especially in Parliament. Let me take this opportunity to congratulate my very supportive and hard-working wife and my mother. Prof, my wife is

hard-working; Mr Rockson will tell you. My mother has always been very supportive. We have had instances where some women have become mothers and fathers. So, when you have a woman who has become a mother and a father, you also need to support, congratulate and commend her.

Some of the women in the constituencies who are Members of Parliament have also become mothers and fathers. They are taking care of a lot of young men and women. They are doing the jobs of men and women. They all need to be highly commended and congratulated.

So, I wish all of us well and I thank you very much for this opportunity, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority? You are yielding to who?

Yes, Hon Ziedeng?

Mr Bede Antwataazumo Ziedeng (NDC — Lawra): Thank you very much. Mr Speaker, except that you should delete the “a” from my name. My name still remains “Ziedeng”. Let me commend my Colleague, Hon Felicia Adjei, for bringing up this matter.

Mr Speaker, the truth of the matter is that I have been an advocate of women’s empowerment and the promotion of gender equity in governance and I have been so for more than a decade, and the battle has been on. Some progress has been achieved through the Affirmative Action law, but that is still not enough

because in terms of legislative participation, the Affirmative Action Act does not adequately address it and I think that we still have a huge gap, which is why even in this Chamber, we see that the women are very few. We have used other ways to address this inequality, but I think that in terms of our electoral system, the only way we can help address this problem is to adopt the proportional representation.

Mr Speaker, that is what Rwanda has done and they have been able to achieve a percentage of over 60 per cent in terms of female representation and they have done so using a combination of systems. They used the proportional representation system and under this proportional representation system, every political party is allowed to fill in its female candidates and then they are allocated the seats based on the votes that they receive. So, it is much easier for women to get included in the list of parliamentarians at the end of the general election. For instance, in the Upper West Region, since we started this exercise in 1992, we have had the opportunity to have only one woman as a parliamentarian and it is always the men. Indeed, I am aware of a lot of women who would do well in Parliament and yet, because of the system that we are applying, first-past-the-post, they are unable to come to Parliament.

Mr Speaker, if we go outside the educational system, in the past, we had very few girls in school, and we came up with a system, we said that we should support the girl child. Today, if we go to all our educational institutions, the girls are now more than the boys because of

the system that we have adopted. So, we have to change our system, which will be fairer. This electoral system that we have is not fair to women and so we have to change it and I think that should be by a legislation. If we do so, then we can accommodate more women in our legislative practice.

Mr Speaker, I think that the time is now and I will support the call by my Colleague, the Member of Parliament for Kintampo South, so that we can reform our electoral system. Currently, it is the electoral system that is the obstacle to the participation of women in the legislative arm of government.

Mr Speaker, with these few remarks, I want to support the call for the reforms and thank my Colleague for bringing up the matter.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Hon Bede Ziedeng.

Hon Members, that brings us to the end of that Statement. We have the next Statement, standing in the name of Davis Ansah Opoku, Member of Parliament for Mpraeso.

Hon Members, in his absence, I will direct that the Statement be published in the *Hansard*.

Kwahu Easter Celebrations; Tourism and Development

Mr Davis Ansah Opoku (NPP — Mpraeso): Mr Speaker, I rise to draw the attention of this honourable House to the national significance of the Easter

celebrations in Kwahu, which have evolved into one of Ghana's most important cultural and tourism events.

Historically, the Easter period in Kwahu has been marked by family reunions, religious activities and community engagement. Over time, this long-standing tradition has expanded beyond its cultural roots into a major driver of domestic tourism and local economic activity. The unique climate, scenic mountain landscape and welcoming communities have positioned Kwahu as a preferred destination during the Easter season.

Mr Speaker, the socio-economic impact of the celebrations is considerable. Hospitality facilities operate at full capacity. Transport services expand. Food vendors, traders, artisans, farmers and small-scale entrepreneurs record increased patronage. The Easter period therefore serves as a vital source of income for thousands of individuals and households. It demonstrates the direct link between culture, tourism and livelihoods. Adventure tourism has also strengthened the Kwahu brand. The paragliding activity over the Kwahu ridge has gained both national and international attention. It reflects how Ghana can leverage its natural landscape to develop distinctive tourism experiences that appeal to a broad demographic.

Mr Speaker, an important policy dimension of Kwahu Easter is the Kwahu Business Forum. This initiative has introduced a structured economic focus to the festivities by creating a

platform for dialogue among entrepreneurs, investors, policy makers and innovators. I commend government for supporting this strategic direction. I also wish to acknowledge the role of Julius Debrah, the current Chief of Staff, whose leadership has been instrumental in shaping the forum into a credible platform that aligns tourism with enterprise development.

Mr Speaker, notwithstanding these successes, significant challenges remain, particularly regarding road infrastructure. Improved access is essential if the full tourism potential of the Kwahu area is to be realised.

Of particular significance is the road network from Akwasiho to Twenedurase through Obo, which links onward through Obomeng to Nkawkaw. These are critical routes that connect the greater Kwahu area. Their condition affects not only residents but also the movement of visitors, goods and services during peak periods such as Easter. When these roads deteriorate, travel time increases, safety is compromised and the attractiveness of the destination is reduced.

Similarly, communities such as Adawso, Asuboni, Nketepa and Amatey possess substantial tourism assets but remain constrained by poor access. These areas feature attractive river falls, forest environments, distinctive rock formations and the well-known stones that appear to be marrying each other, all of which have strong potential for eco-tourism and heritage tourism. However, without reliable roads, these assets cannot be effectively developed or marketed.

Mr Speaker, upgrading these roads is therefore a strategic economic intervention. Improved infrastructure will facilitate year-round tourism, stimulate local enterprise, create employment opportunities for the youth and enhance market access for farmers and small businesses. It will also support the government's broader objectives of regional development and domestic tourism promotion.

In conclusion, Kwahu Easter has transcended its origins as a seasonal gathering and has become a national tourism asset. It promotes Ghanaian culture, supports livelihoods and demonstrates the economic value of well-organised cultural events.

I take this opportunity to respectfully invite you, Mr Speaker, and Honourable Members of this House to visit Kwahu during the Easter period to observe firsthand the cultural vibrancy, business activity and tourism potential of the area. Such engagement will reinforce parliamentary appreciation of tourism as a viable instrument for national development.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

[Published by Order of Mr Speaker]

Introduction of Malaria Vaccines

Mrs Philis Naa Koryoo Okunor (NDC — Awutu Senya East): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity.

Mr Speaker, distinguished Members of Parliament, fellow Ghanaians, I rise

today on behalf of the people of Awutu Senya East constituency, Kasoa, particularly its mothers and children, to draw this august House's urgent attention to a public health milestone that has the potential to transform the destinies of our nation.

Mr Speaker, Ghana stands at the forefront of one of the most remarkable public health achievements of the early 21st century, the drastic reduction in child mortality through the introduction of a new malaria vaccine, a breakthrough many of our constituents believed they would never live to see.

1:21 p.m.

Mr Speaker, in countries like Ghana, these new vaccines have contributed to an extraordinary decline in child deaths. Official figures reveal those deaths among children below five plummeted by nearly 86 per cent as at two years ago from 2018. This is a testament to the power of preventive immunisation against one of the oldest scourges of our continent.

Mr Speaker, this is not abstract data. These are lives saved. The laughter of children now walking to school, the relief on parents faces, knowing a healthy tomorrow is possible. The economic benefits of our families, not grieving the death of an innocent child is real. This is real progress.

Mr Speaker, this progress, however, is under threat. Despite these gains, international support, particularly from major donors, is being scaled down.

Funding cuts to critical global health alliance that supports malaria vaccinations, including reductions in contributions to Gavi, the Vaccine Alliance could result in thousands of preventable child deaths of children under five and pregnant women in countries like Ghana, who depend on the support.

Mr Speaker, in the face of unwavering international support, I submit these two critical calls to action. One, increasing domestic financing for malaria vaccinations programme to reduce our dependence on volatile external fundings. Two, to strengthen vaccines logistics and cold chain systems, especially in rural and hard-to-reach communities, so, no child is left behind because of geography.

Mr Speaker, today, we honour the courage of Ghanaian mothers who bring their children to clinics, the dedication of our nurses, and health workers and the vision of global health partners. But we cannot stand complacency while the foundation of this progress wobble.

Mr Speaker, let us be a Parliament that ensures the gains against malaria did not slip away. Let us be known as leaders who delivered healthy security for Ghana's children. Let our actions be the legacy Ghana's parents and their children can look back on with pride.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, and all the Hon Members for their audience. May God bless our motherland. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member you have the floor.

Dr Abdul-Khaliq Mohammed Sherif (NDC — Nanton): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity to contribute to the Statement made by the Hon Member.

Malaria, as we all know, is one of the killer diseases that we have in Africa and Ghana. The whole essence of vaccination is to ensure that people build immunity against future infections. Ghana is gradually shifting from malaria control to malaria elimination. The aim is to reduce deaths that occur through malaria by 90 per cent and also reduce this case incidence by about 50 per cent. Ghana is doing this through what we call the National Malaria Strategic Elimination Programme between 2024 and 2028.

The key strategies that are used here include enhanced surveillance, the widespread use of insecticide-treated mosquito nets, indoor residual spraying, larval source management, and seasonal malaria chemo prevention. As part of the vaccines, two key vaccines are used in Ghana currently. From 2019, we were using the vaccine known as the RTS,S/AS01.

Currently, we are using the vaccine known as the R21/Matrix-M. That one is usually used in malaria endemic areas. What is the protocol we are using as a county? We are saying that every child under the age of five should get about four doses, starting from six months, seven months, nine months, and 18 months.

With this, what we have achieved so far is that, we have been able to reduce our in-patient malaria mortality from 428 in 2018 to 115 in 2022. We have also been able to cut the parasite prevalence rate in children under five from 20.6 per cent in 2014 to about 14 per cent in 2022. We all know that because of what is happening in the United States of America, our international partners like Gavi, the Vaccine Alliance, are shifting out of the country. But the Government of H. E. John Dramani Mahama—If we listened carefully to the President when he presented the Message on the State of the Nation, he made it clear that the Government was allocating US\$50 million in the area of vaccine production within Ghana. It is to provide vaccine for our children, to increase local content and provide employment.

Mr Speaker, if we cast our minds back to somewhere around 2022 to 2023, children in Ghana, which is 69 years, could not get key vaccines like BCG, measles and so on. But thankfully, now, that situation is a thing of the past. As Gavi is leaving and as Government has put aside this money, it is my belief that malaria, which used to be the number one killer—If you had gone through a hospital, they would tell you malaria is the number one killer. But for now, through the intervention of Government and the use of the three “Ts” which is to test, treat and you track, most of our hospitals now are recording lower incidence of malaria and our children who used to die, especially those under five, are living much longer.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leadership?

Majority Chief Whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor): Mr Speaker, let me commend the Member for bringing this matter to national attention.

Mr Speaker, just a couple of months ago, we passed the National Vaccines Institute Act, 2023, (Act 1097) to law and it has been established. If you consider the work that the new entity has done, led by Dr Sodzi Sodzi-Tettey; it is very profound. So, I have been wondering why it took us so long to establish the National Vaccine Institute. Being such a young entity, they are doing big things. It is such a big boost to local production of such critical vaccines for ailments that have afflicted us for centuries, I should say, especially malaria.

It is a very good thing that is brought to attention. I believe that in their programmes, they will pay attention to the issues that she raised in her Statement, so that in funding, entities that will benefit from it can actually utilise them for the benefit of the health industry.

Mr Speaker, what we are also saying is that, they should not centralise some of these programmes. They should go to the regions and establish them because the centralisation is not helping. We have a lot of regional hospitals that are still reeling from the inadequacies of such facilities.

As a Member, I would pray that the Committee on Health pays attention. I saw the Chairman and some of the Members on the floor a while ago. They should pay attention to some of these things, so that in their regional rounds, they can pay critical attention to how these are developing in the districts and regions.

Mr Speaker, with these words, I thank the Member for bringing this matter to attention. Thank you very much.

1:31 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: That brings us to the end of that Statement. We then move to the Statement lettered (h) standing in the name of Hon Lawrence Agyinsam.

Connecting Entrepreneurs in the Micro, Small and Medium-Sized Enterprises Landscape in Ghana

Mr Lawrence Agyinsam (NPP — Hemang Lower Denkyira): Mr Speaker, I rise to make a Statement on the importance of connecting entrepreneurs in the Micro, Small and Medium-Sized Enterprises (MSME) landscape in Ghana. This was a commemorative statement last year, but it is finding its place now. This day presents an opportunity to raise awareness of the importance of entrepreneurs in the Ghanaian economy and take actionable steps toward building a sustainable MSME outlook in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, in Ghana, the informal sector of the economy is clothed in numerous MSMEs where massive economic activities are performed. However, the transformative capacity of the MSMEs has for a long period been ignored.

Mr Speaker, with your leave, I want to highlight Ghana's MSME statistical background. Ghana has about 1.9 million business establishments. Out of this, a total of 1.7 million are micro-sized enterprises, of which 464,100, which represent 27.3 per cent, was recorded in the Ashanti region. In the Greater Accra region, there was a record of 379,100, representing 22.3 per cent, whereas the remaining 14 regions cumulatively recorded 857,800 MSMEs, which represent 50.4 per cent.

Mr Speaker, it will interest you to know that these businesses operate with approximately one to five employees and mostly lack the motivation to innovate. According to the Ghana Statistical Service, approximately 70 per cent of Ghana's Gross Domestic Product (GDP) is attributed to the economic activities of MSMEs, whereas the United Nations Development Programme, (UNDP), emphasises that these enterprises have been pivotal across various sectors of the Ghanaian economy, accounting for over 90 per cent of businesses which span from agriculture, manufacturing, services and trade.

Mr Speaker, in the employment sector, MSMEs have a share of about 80 per cent of Ghana's labour force. Specifically, they account for about 85

per cent of employment within the manufacturing sector, highlighting their significance in job creation and industrial development, as well as economic development. This brings me to the focus of today's discussion, the entrepreneurs. The entrepreneurs in Ghana, who are hypothetically the brains of engine behind Small and Medium-Sized Enterprises (SMEs), drive an often neglected in terms of access to capital, that is finance and innovation. In emerging and developing economies, the International Trade Centre (ITC), estimates that SMEs financing gap as of 2020 was estimated as 19 per cent, equivalent to US\$5.7 trillion. Nearly 70 per cent of SMEs do not have access to funds from financial institutions while additional 15 per cent are under finance. As a result, many SMEs rely on less-than-ideal resources, such as internal funds or informal sources like family and friends to sustain their operation.

Mr Speaker, in Ghana, most businesses shut down due to inadequate capitalisation and access, especially for women. According to International Trade Centre data, 45 per cent of women-managed businesses face financial constraints, compared to 27 per cent of men-managed businesses. Globally, over one million women do not use or lack access to formal financial systems. This has led to financing gap for formal women-owned small businesses of US\$1.9 trillion. This is why government must increase the funds allocated to the Women's Development Bank to fast track its establishment. The idea of Women's Development Bank is commendable, and this can be used as a policy tool to connect women entrepreneurs.

Mr Speaker, moreover, savings groups and corporations must be incentivised to formalise their services to extend access to capital to budding entrepreneurs, especially women, in rural communities such as my constituency, which is the home to one of Ghana's famous tourist sites, the Kakum National Park.

Mr Speaker, on this note, kindly indulge me to plead with entrepreneurs to visit the Hemang Lower Denkyira Constituency, a constituency which is ripe with business opportunities such as oil palm plantation and processing, as well as rubber production and processing. Launching a national campaign on MSME academies and boot camps through Ghana Enterprise Agency (GEA), and National Entrepreneurship Innovation Programme, (NEIP), is another policy initiative to consider. The campaign will see the affordability of finance by expanding the range of financing instrument beyond traditional banks, loans, and leverage digital technologies to reduce costs and expand outreach, and incentivise public-private synergies to de-risk and expand SME funding. Digital transformation cannot be ignored when discussing measures to connect entrepreneurs in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, digital technologies are pivotal for boosting MSME performance. For instance, e-commerce platforms can help companies to reduce such information costs, making it faster, easier, and cheaper to connect with buyers. These platforms have the capacity to connect businesses to foreign countries, which will allow them to sell beyond domestic markets.

Mr Speaker, digital transformation in Ghana must be a shared responsibility. As such, I propose some actions that can drive progress. There is a need for increased affordability. This can be achieved through encouraging public and private investment in broadband expansion, reducing the cost of internet connectivity, and enabling access to data processing infrastructure. There is also the need to close the skills gap. This can be done by integrating digital skills in education and training through establishing more Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics (STEM) schools, which the previous administration had already started, and foster digital talent mobility.

Mr Speaker, in concluding, Ghana can become the entrepreneurial hub of Africa when Ghanaian entrepreneurs and businesses are given the right support by bringing them together on a common pedestal where innovation, productivity, and healthy competition is the trademark.

Mr Speaker, thank you, for the opportunity to speak to these issues.

Mr Sebastian Fred Deh (NDC — Kpando): Mr Speaker, thank you. I want to thank the maker of the Statement, Hon Lawrence Agyinsam for such a beautiful work. I think this could not have come at a better time. We held a celebration of the Ghanaian entrepreneur, how they matter and why they matter. I think that the importance of the entrepreneur in the micro-SME sector cannot be overemphasised without repeating some of the things that my Hon Colleague has

already enumerated for us, it is important for us to remember that these set of people that drive 80 per cent of employment, the much talked about unemployment situation. These are the people who drive over 80 per cent of it and also 17 per cent of GDP. They cover a wide range of economic activities, from baking to food making to selling of cosmetics *et cetera* and these entrepreneurs, who operate in the micro-SME sector, adapt very fast to local needs. We attend funerals and all the major economic activities we see around are controlled by these people.

1:41 p.m.

Call it selling of funeral paraphernalia, food or any other thing that will make people feel good at such functions. These people also turn informal trade into registered businesses. They actually form the starting point of our businesses in Ghana. This, for me, is the importance why these people must be celebrated.

Four things which were espoused by the maker of the Statement which I risk to emphasise is that easier and cheaper financing is the most important thing that will make this sector grow. How this can be carried out to the doorstep of the entrepreneur is what we need to emphasise as a Nation. I was happy to hear from the Statement that the issue of a Women's Development Bank which has been so well established in all the documents that have been placed before Parliament as coming from the ruling Government as one of the things that will be done to boost the micro-SME sector would come into being.

What we also need to remember is sharpening the practical skills of these people. It is important as a way of boosting the sector. I must also add that how we make regulation or how we make formalising of this informal sector possible and better, or how we make it easier for them to formalise their informal trade is important.

I wish to thank the maker of the Statement that such brilliant ideas have been exposed on the floor of Parliament at such a time that we are actually preparing to take off as a nation as far as business is concerned. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, indulge me to take a two-minute suspension.

1:45 p.m. — *Sitting suspended*

1:48 p.m. — *Sitting resumed.*

[HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER,
MR BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE
CHAIR]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, continuation of comments. Hon Stephen Amoah?

Dr Stephen Amoah (NPP — Nhyiaeso): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for this prestigious opportunity.

First, I would like to commend the Hon Member who presented this very important Statement. Mr Speaker, when it comes to the issue of SMEs in Ghana, it is time we give it the needed

attention and priority as a country in terms of our state policies, especially when we are trying to find a long-term solution to dealing with the consolidation of our fiscal space.

I am saying this because, as stated here, SMEs play an important role in our ecosystem as a country. However, there are so many challenges confronting SME actors in our country today, contributing to the sinusoidal performance of our economy and our inability to be fully independent as a sovereign nation. There are two main extracts in the Statement that I would like to concentrate on: one, capitalisation, and two, consolidating the various SMEs dimensions in our country.

It looks as if we are not leveraging our advantage and opportunity as a country. I am saying this because there seems to be a very big gap between the opportunities that we accord large-scale corporate bodies and these SMEs in our country. If we can realise this and do something about it as a country, it will go a long way to help us attain the long-term economic growth and stability that have been so challenging to us as a country.

For SMEs in Ghana, when it comes to the cost of even borrowing, it is not comparable to most of their colleagues within the West Africa sovereignty. For some of them, the interest rate is beyond 45 per cent and some 50 per cent. Even access to them is a problem. There are inadequate funds on our market simply because of the risk factors that are positioned with them.

So, Mr Speaker, if we can connect them, as the maker of this Statement is concerned about, first, as a country, we need to accord SMEs the needed opportunity to, one, have adequate funds, and two, to have funds that come with less cost; costs that can be competitive enough. Some of these things do not even attract investors. They seem to be getting closer to our neighbouring countries because of some of these opportunities. Most of the actors of even this very segment of our socioeconomic framework are not experienced. So, even sometimes they are given funds, the money goes bad. They cannot even pay back because they do not have people who have the know-how.

Mr Speaker, let us not forget the fact that one of the key functions of performance is ability. So, we can even give them the funds, but without the appropriate orientation and training the monies given to them will go bad, and the sustainability of SMEs in our country can never be realised.

Even within the government-owned sector, whether government A or B, we have come to realise that we have a lot of institutions positioning themselves in a way to capitalise these SMEs. I think there are too many. We found out with the previous government, and we are still finding that with this Government. Can we sit down and try to consolidate the effort of these state-owned institutions that are capitalising these SMEs? Even Microfinance and Loans Centre (MASLOC) can be made like Ghana Commercial Bank (GCB) in

Ghana, but solely for the SMEs. It has to be properly run—

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib (NPP — Weija-Gbawe): I want to take this opportunity to thank the maker of this Statement, Hon Agyinsam, MP for Hemang Lower Denkyira, on virtually connecting entrepreneurs to the SMEs landscape in Ghana.

Just going through the Statement, there are a few revelations. One is that when we are talking about Micro, it is about one to about five people who are supposed to be employed within a certain setup. Then when we come down to talk about the Small, then we are looking at about between six to 30. When we are talking about Medium, it is about 31 to 100.

Mr Speaker, what this generally does is that it tells us that SMEs provide a lot of employment. So, employment from SMEs alone is not less than 90 per cent within the Ghanaian landscape. So, what are we doing to keep them active and to keep them operational?

Secondly, when we come down, we also realise that most SMEs lack very basic support, especially with reference to financial support. This is because they do not have the wherewithal to even be able to access basic loans to work. When it comes to SMEs, going for loans, the kind of facilities they are to look for and the guarantees that they are expected to provide is sometimes very unconscionable. It is so harsh that they are unable to meet same. So, my request would rather be that we should be thinking of how best

the Government can put in structures that would make them assess loans without these kinds of harsh restrictions.

The commendation to the Government would have come in if the Government had even considered fast-tracking the Women's Development Bank. This is because if the Women's Development Bank were to be active today, most SMEs would have gone to the bank to aid them, especially the women. One of the contributors even made the point that most of these people are found to be in baking. They also sell; it is the basic things but they are not even getting the monies to do so. If we are able to improve upon such, a lot of problems would be solved.

Mr Speaker, another challenge they face is high interest rates from the banks. Most SMEs are unable to pay the kind of interest that they are requested to. When they go in, they take the monies and then the next thing is that they vanish into thin air; we cannot find them again. Why? Because even data on them is also a problem.

2:01 p.m.

Mr Speaker, we are also aware that people even take facilities from Mobile Money (MOMO) accounts, and the next thing they do is throw the SIM card away because they are unable to pay. But when data is well-captured, we are sure that people who would even go for such facilities would be emboldened to use them for the purposes for which they went, and they can pay back and expand employment and business.

Mr Speaker, I think that if we should look more at some of these things — poor infrastructure. Yesterday, I was in my home in my constituency, while I was discussing constituency matters, which obviously does not correlate with SME, the lights went off. When we are looking at the issue of poor infrastructure, we are looking at electricity, which is also tabled. When there is consistency in the supply of electricity, business people are able to do their business, especially those that deal with cold store facilities or storage facilities. So, Mr Speaker, that is another thing we should look at, and the kind of technical skills some of —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Majority Bench?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, let me commend my Brother, Mr Lawrence Agyinsam, for this very good Statement. Mr Speaker, I would not belabour some of the points raised by my other Colleagues. One of the key problems adversely affecting SMEs in obtaining easy facilities is improper records. It is such a big problem; they do not even keep proper books of accounts. And it is replete with some of the academic studies that have been done. So, as a people, we need to gradually move towards keeping proper books of accounts and registering the entities with the Registrar General's Department.

Mr Speaker, if you recall, during the COVID-19 era, when businesses and entities were supposed to benefit from the COVID-19 package, record-keeping became a problem. That is why the

Auditor-General found for a fact that some of those windfall packages had to be paid from the top of the table as cash. This is because entities were not registered. They did not have any records. They cannot even account for the money that they gave to the people. Again, when they take the facilities, people decide to do other things from the purpose for which the funds were given. One is given a stimulus package but decides to go and develop their home and there is poor accountability.

Inasmuch as we are trying to draw attention to the problems they face and how government can intervene, the SMEs themselves — the penchant to always make the SMEs a sole proprietorship, is a one-man business; the person decides the fate of the business. We should move away from that into proper recordkeeping. There can be sole proprietorship, but when the records are properly kept and properly registered, some of these packages that the government rolls out can come their way.

Mr Speaker, these days, when some of these Statements are made, the relevant Committees should be paying attention and taking note of the issues, so that in their programmes of activities where they go around, or they exercise oversight, they can pay attention and bring about reforms. This is because legislation is not always the only way to ensure that reforms come about in some of these sectors. When Hon Members make Statements or ask Questions, they are all part of tools that are available to us to ensure that we bring reforms.

So, the Committee on Trade, Industry and Tourism should pay attention to the issues the Hon Members raised, as well as those contained in the Statement for their attention. Mr Speaker, with these words, I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, that brings us to the end of the Statement under reference. I will proceed to give the floor to Hon Dickson Kyere-Duah, Member of Parliament for Berekum West.

Stakeholder Commitment to Methane Reduction for Climate Action

Mr Dickson Kyere-Duah (NDC — Berekum West): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to make this urgent Statement on the need for all stakeholders to commit to methane reduction and mitigation measures as a quick solution to address climate change. Mr Speaker, following my participation in the Methane Session of the Inter-Parliamentary Union (IPU), parliamentary meeting at COP 30 in Brazil last year, I rise to make this profound Statement on the urgent need for all stakeholders to commit to methane reduction and mitigation measures, which are among the quickest ways to combat climate change.

Mr Speaker, as the world grapples with the escalating impacts of climate change, methane reduction has emerged as one of the most cost-effective and fastest ways to slow global warming. Methane is a harmful greenhouse gas that heats the Earth more than 80 times as much as carbon dioxide over a 20-year

period. It accounts for about 30 per cent of the global temperature rise since the pre-industrial era. Methane is the second largest contributor to climate change after carbon dioxide.

Mr Speaker, methane is a global issue with local consequences. When released into the atmosphere, it reacts with other gases to form ground-level ozone, a toxic air pollutant that causes about one million premature deaths globally each year. It harms food systems by reducing food yields of essential staples like rice, wheat and soya by 5-10 per cent each year, thereby threatening global food security.

Mr Speaker, anthropogenic activities, that is, human activities, account for 60 per cent of global methane emissions. Agriculture is the largest emitter, 40 per cent, with energy sources such as fossil fuels accounting for 35 per cent, waste management 20 per cent, and the other sources account for a meagre 5 per cent. Mr Speaker, unlike carbon dioxide, methane stays in the atmosphere for only a decade, meaning that cutting methane emissions now can deliver rapid, tangible, and health benefits within our lifetimes.

Mr Speaker, under the distinguished Leadership of the Rt Hon Speaker of this Parliament, Alban Sumana Kingsford Bagbin, Ghana has demonstrated strong political commitment to climate action through active collaboration with the IPU. This partnership continues to build the capacity of Members of Parliament by providing opportunities to participate in the Global Methane Project, which

seeks to strengthen Parliamentary engagement in the development and oversight of methane reduction policies.

Mr Speaker, in October last year, the Rt Hon Speaker Babin officially launched a strategic partnership with the IPU under the project titled “Enhancing Parliamentary Action on Climate Change, Strengthening the Role of Parliament in Reducing Methane Emission”. Mr Speaker, with the support of the IPU, the Rt Hon Speaker organised a three-day workshop and a site visit to rice farms in the Eastern Region of Ghana.

2:08 p.m.

Mr Speaker, with the support of the Inter-Parliamentary Union (IPU), the Rt Hon Speaker organised a three-day workshop and a site visit to rice farms in the Eastern Region of Ghana to engage farmers on the modern farming practices to tackle methane emissions effectively.

Mr Speaker, Parliament has the power to turn commitments into tangible outcomes through laws, through budgets and oversight. In this regard, I would like to suggest that this honourable House take a more proactive role in the National Methane Reduction Agenda in the following areas.

First, budgetary consideration and resource allocation: I recall that at the launch of the strategic partnership with IPU last year, the Rt Hon Speaker urged the Budget Committee of this House to allocate substantial funds for climate action, especially those aimed at

methane reduction. We have a responsibility as Members of Parliament to ensure that Ministries, Agencies and parliamentary Committees are adequately funded to deliver our methane mandate.

Second, legislative and policy review: Parliament should consider opportunities to review and strengthen existing environmental, agricultural, energy and waste management laws and policies and include clear methane reduction measures.

Third, stimulating national debate and citizens' participation: Members of this House should promote national awareness and encourage citizens' participation in methane reduction and mitigation efforts through Statements, debates and Motions in this Chamber.

Fourth, I suggest that the Committee on Environment, Science and Technology should hold annual progress hearings on Ghana's methane reduction efforts by inviting relevant Ministries and Agencies to report on milestones and challenges they are facing. This will enhance transparency and accountability while maintaining political momentum.

Mr Speaker, the task before us is clear. It is time to move from commitment to action, from pledges to tangible results. Ghana's partnership with the IPU and other allies on the methane project shows clearly that parliamentary leadership can make a significant difference, not only in formulating policies but also in holding climate promises to account.

Mr Speaker, by reducing methane emissions, we improve air quality, safeguard families, boost energy efficiency and protect public health. It is therefore both a climate necessity and a moral duty.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for indulging me.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Statement has been made.

Yes, Hon Arko Nokoe?

Mr Kofi Arko Nokoe (NDC — Evalue-Ajomoro-Gwira): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to what I consider a very crucial Statement made by my Colleague and Friend.

Mr Speaker, climate change is real, and coming from Evalue-Gwira, the coastal man from Axim, the effect of climate change, the rise of tidal waves, the destruction it causes from Axim all the way to Keta, is real evidence that climate action is something that cannot be kicked over the line. But what is more revealing is that all this while, the trend has been on carbon dioxide. Climate change has been centred on carbon dioxide, that it is one of the most dangerous components. But today, it is insightful to learn that methane is rather 80 times more harmful than carbon dioxide and that is why I want to join in commending the Rt Hon Speaker in his own wisdom, after understanding and appreciating the threat of methane, to push for an awareness on the need of this country to battle it.

Mr Speaker, I was at the workshop, and it was amazing to learn that even open waste—We know how many constituencies and as a country how we are confronted with waste management. It is that the emission from waste is just serious. I want to say that as a nation I believe we started, it is not a one-day event; it is a process, but we must, as my Colleague suggested, attach more seriousness, more commitment to it. Because if we lose this fight, we, those in the sub-Saharan, excuse me to say the poor nations on this globe, suffer more. We bear the brunt, the severest of brunt when it comes to climate action and climate consequences.

So, I want to commend my Colleague once again and I believe that I will add weight to his call. And as a nation, we cannot fail. We must fight this fight and put all the resources that is needed to ensure that we save this world, not only for ourselves, but the future generations.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

M First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Stephen Amoah?

Dr Stephen Amoah (NPP — Nhyiaeso): Thank you once again, Mr Speaker. First, I would like to commend the maker of the Statement because of its importance, Mr Speaker, not only because of us as a country, but because of our continent and the globe. What is prevailing today is indicative of the fact that as a sovereignty, we need to begin a new task. A new task of approaching this whole climate change, designing a new

paradigm shift because we think we are not feeling it tangibly. I see something different because once it happens in Africa, the probability that it is getting to us is extremely high enough for us to accord it the needed concentration.

Mr Speaker, there are countries in Africa that are experiencing increased migration because of climate change. They are leaving the country. They are closing schools because temperature went as high as 45 degrees Celsius in Sudan and other parts of the world. It is affecting food, it is affecting water, it is affecting livelihood and it is deteriorating the economies and I think we cannot run away from that.

Mr Speaker, allow me to use this adage — *[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]* —

Mr Speaker, we are not far from the consequences our brothers from other parts of our continent are being confronted with. We need to put in place contingency measures. Because of time constraints, I would like to suggest only one thing, research. We need to prioritise our research into some of these areas.

Mr Speaker, if you read, I think, Ghana National Research Act, 2020 (Act 1056), which stipulates that about 0.5 per cent of our annual revenue budget has to go into research and development. I think the makers of that law had in mind some of these critical issues to be dealt with. However, I wonder if we as a country, whether government A or B, actually adhere to this. If not, I would like to base on this important Statement to admonish

the present authority to make sure that going forward, at least, 0.5 per cent of our budget revenue goes into research and development. Substantial amount of this proportion must go into the areas

2:18 p.m.

Yes, that we can actually attain the requisite knowledge when it comes to climate change so we can continue to put in place measures and contingencies and then policies or policy frameworks that will really put us in a position that we will not be found wanting one day. I think just as the whole world is battling this, we as a country and as a sovereignty being part of this whole global domain should take it very seriously. Apart from that, I would like to say that as a House, we need to continue to accord climate change as one of the important issues to work on and make sure that we would not one day get into that situation. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Hon Stephen Amoah, except that the words in twi that has not been translated into English is hereby ordered to be expunged from the record.

Dr Amoah: Mr Speaker, can I explain?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leadership?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I will yield but if not—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, Majority Leadership?

Dr Amoah: Mr Speaker, can I translate my words if I could have the opportunity?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We have passed through that stage. It is now the turn of the Majority.

Dr Amoah: Oh, he is my brother—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, you should be observing the rules. The rule says official language is English.

Dr Amoah: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I yield to Hon Dr Mohammed Sherif.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor.

Dr Abdul-Khaliq Mohammed Sherif (NDC — Nanton): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker for this opportunity to associate myself with the Statement made by my Colleague. Mr Speaker, if you look at the issues of climate change and the greenhouse gases. Like they said initially, most of the time we have just been looking at carbon dioxide, but there are other gases within the atmosphere that contributes to the greenhouse effect that includes nitrous oxide, methane, even water vapour is part of their contribution. The issues of climate change go beyond just what we see. If we look generally in the world, we now have issues of climate change related to gender, conflict, et cetera but let us come back home to Africa.

Mr Speaker, Africa contributes just about 4 per cent to greenhouse emission, even though we house just about 17 per cent of the world population. But the effect and impact of global warming is felt immensely in Africa, where we have rising sunshine, rising heat, melting of the ice block, flooding, tsunamis, *et cetera*. Through all these ones, in 2000 alone, Africa's emission was about 0.8 metric tonnes per compound, as compared to 3.9 that is done worldwide. This still tells us how little we contribute to greenhouse effect, but what happens? At the end of the day, when Africa goes out to the world to ask for mitigation effect and aid, the feeling we get as Africans is that we have come cup in hand. But I think it is just legitimate that a continent that does less but feels more effect, the rest of the world should be able to cushion us.

Mr Speaker, it is estimated that Africa loses about US\$7 to US\$15 billion each year to climate change and it is estimated that this amount is going to go up to as much as US\$30 billion by 2030. So it makes this issue of climate change very critical. I am just from Tamale and in the past two days, temperatures are rising between 39 and 40 degrees. People are fasting in the Northern Region. People are dehydrating. People's kidneys are getting a shot. In the next few years, we are going to feel the effect of that climate change on the health of the people of the Northern Region and the ordinary Ghanaian. So, what we are saying is that this issue of climate change is very critical. This House and the entirety of Ghanaians need to contribute to make sure that we are reducing our effect on the greenhouse emission. What can we do as a country?

Worldwide, the issue of carbon credits is coming up, where countries, *et cetera*, are giving aid depending on how they are cutting on carbon emission. The other thing we can do: look around our communities and Ghana, we are cutting down trees to put up high-rise buildings. We are cutting down even trees along water bodies. At the end of the day, we create climate change problems. At the end of the day, we have our fellows from Niger and Senegal walking upon our streets. Sometimes we are not happy to see them, but do we know why they are here, Mr Speaker? The issue of climate change. There is drought in Senegal, Cameroon and those areas. What do the people have to do? They would rather move towards where they can have self-sufficiency.

Mr Speaker, like my Colleague said, it is a very serious issue. This House must take it very seriously. If not, at the end of the day, we are going to spend so much of the money that we do not have to solve the problems of climate change. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you. Hon Members, that Statement has also ended. We will take Statement number (k), standing in the name of Hon Solomon Kuyon, Member of Parliament for Krachi-Nchumuru.

Urgent Need for a National Youth Development Fund

Mr Solomon Kuyon (NDC — Krachi-Nchumuru): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make a

Statement on the importance of the urgent need for a National Youth Development Fund. Mr Speaker, I am grateful for the opportunity to make this important Statement on the Floor of this august House. I rise today not to speak of problems, but of potential. I rise to speak of our nation's greatest and most abundant resource, the energy, the ambition, and the boundless imagination of the Ghanaian youth. From the fishing communities along the Volta Lake, my constituency of Krachi-Nchumuru and to the bustling tech hubs of Accra, there is a generation of young people who are not waiting for the future. They are ready to build it themselves. But readiness is not enough, ambition must be met with opportunity. A dream, no matter how brilliant, cannot take flight without the wing of capital beneath its wings.

The reality in Krachi-Nchumuru as it is in countless constituencies across our nation, is that we have a generation of talent that is being held back by a single formidable barrier: the lack of accessible, patient and empowering finance. We have young graduates with innovative agribusiness ideas who cannot afford their first piece of land. We have brilliant young women who have mastered a trade but cannot afford the tools to start their own workshop. We have tech-savvy youth with world-changing ideas who have no path to seed funding. We have, in essence, a national engine of innovation that is idling, waiting for the full world to ignite it.

Mr Speaker, this is not a critique of any single government or policy. It is a recognition of a structural gap in our

national development architecture. For too long, our approach to youth empowerment has been a patchwork of short-term programmes and temporary interventions. While well-intentioned, these initiatives often lack the skill, the sustainability, and the long-term vision required to address a challenge of this magnitude. They provide temporary relief, but they do not build permanent pathways to prosperity.

2:28 p.m.

The time has come for a bolder, more permanent vision. That is why I stand here today to propose the establishment of a National Youth Development Fund. This will not be just another government programme subject to the shifting priorities of annual budgets. I envision a dedicated, professionally managed and politically independent national endowment established by an Act of this Parliament. A Fund that is insulated from the vagaries of political cycles with a governance structure that commands the confidence of the private sector, our development partners and most importantly, the young people it is designed to serve.

This Fund must operate not as a handout but as a strategic long-term investment in the future economic and social architecture of Ghana. The mission of this Fund will be clear and focused to provide the critical missing link between youthful ambition and economic reality. It will be built on three core pillars, each designed to address a specific stage of the youth economic journey.

Pillar one, seed capital for youth start-ups. This is the fundamental, this is the foundational pillar. It will provide macro grants and low-interest, concessionary loans to young entrepreneurs aged 18 to 35, enabling them to launch their first business ventures. This is for the young woman in Chinderi who needs a new oven for her bakery. The young man in Kete-Krachi who needs to buy his own fishing nets, or the graduates in Accra who need to purchase a laptop to start a graphic design business. This pillar is about democratising the opportunity to try to innovate and to take that first crucial step towards self-reliance.

Pillar two, scale up financing for growth. The second pillar is about identifying and nurturing success. The Fund will provide a second tier of financing, venture capital and growth loans for promising youth-led small and medium-sized enterprises that have demonstrated viability and have the potential to scale. The goal here is not just to create self-employment but to create employees. We must invest in the young entrepreneurs who can grow their businesses from two employees to 10, from 10 to 50, creating a powerful multiplier effect on job creation across the country.

Pillar three, skills and innovation grants. The third pillar recognises that capital alone is not enough. The Fund will provide dedicated grants to support modern apprenticeships, market-relevant vocational training and the establishment of innovation and technology hubs in every region of Ghana. This ensures that the skills we are teaching our youth are

directly linked to the demands of the 21st century economy. It will support the master craftsmen who are passing on their knowledge and fund the co-working spaces where the next generation of Ghanaian tech innovators can collaborate and create tech innovations and collaborate and create.

Mr Speaker, this is not a partisan issue. The challenge of youth unemployment does not wear the colours of the National Democratic Congress (NDC) or the New Patriotic Party (NPP). It is a national challenge that demands a national consensus. The aspirations of a young person in my constituency are no different from the aspirations of a young person in any other constituency.

I therefore call on the leadership of this House to form a bipartisan working group, drawing Members from both Sides of the aisle to begin the urgent work of drafting the enabling legislation that will bring this Fund to life. Let us work together to design a sustainable funding mechanism. Let us exploit, for instance, a small dedicated levy on the profits of our extractive or telecommunications sectors, industries that benefit immensely from our national resources and our national markets. Let us create a framework that attracts contributions from our international development partners and encourages corporate social responsibility investment from the private sector. Let us back this with a dedicated multi-year budgetary allocation from the state to build an endowment that will save the generation of Ghanaians yet to come.

Mr Speaker, let me conclude by speaking directly to the young people of Krachi Nchumuru and indeed all of Ghana. We see your potential. We hear your aspirations, and we understand that your success is inextricably linked to the success of our nation. You are not the leaders of tomorrow. You are the leaders of today, waiting for the tools to build a better Ghana. Investing in you is the single greatest economic decision we can make. It is how we transform our demographic dividend from a potential risk into a historic opportunity. It is how we build a more inclusive, prosperous and resilient nation from the ground up. Let this Ninth Parliament be remembered not for its division, but for its unity of purpose on this critical issue. Let us be remembered as the generation of leaders who did not just talk about the future but took the bold, decisive and historic step to fund it.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Dominic Bingab Aduna Nitiwul (NPP — Bimbilla): Mr Speaker, I want to support the maker of the Statement. It is a very good call. The National Youth Development Fund concept is not new. In fact, in the Eastern African countries, it is very widespread. There is Namibia and many other countries that have that fund. In those countries, the fund primarily fills a certain gap. Because when a young person completes school, the difficulty of having collateral to be able to get a loan is very high. So, they use this fund to provide collateral-free loans for the young people and also virtually interest-free loans because the

interest is per annum between two to four per cent. If we can do this for the young people of this country, I am quite sure that a lot of them with very good entrepreneurial ideas will succeed.

2:38 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I want to support him and say that we should target the young people, not allow the fund to degenerate or the fund to be like the Microfinance and Small Loans Centre (MASLOC) fund or all these kind of funds that people believe that they have become political funds, where we bring the fund and we are only looking at our party members and constituency members; no. It should be a fund that should support the young people of Ghana. With all the loose money around, we can pull it together and tie it to the Consolidated Development Bank, or the Agricultural Development Bank, which would continuously be funding this and the Government should support them. Like I said, if we target certain core areas like agriculture, Information Communication Technology (ICT), manufacturing, creative industry and tourism, we can get the youth to focus on these areas and I am quite sure that we will succeed.

Mr Speaker, how can we explain to people that we are importing sugar to the tune of over GH¢2 billion? We are importing rice to the tune of over GH¢2 billion? How? Why should we be doing that? We should change it, because we have very fertile lands. If you have the opportunity to fly across Ghana, especially in the southern sector, what we call the forest belt, Mr Speaker, you

will be amazed by the quality of land that we have. So, we have the land and we should be able to get some of our young people to do that.

President Houphouët-Boigny, in those days, before a person took up a ministerial position, one of the guiding principles he had was whether they had a cocoa farm or a farm; otherwise, he would not make them a Minister. Even if one becomes a Minister, one must make sure that they have a big cocoa farm. The Government will help secure the land and will ensure that they do the farming to support. So, if we get our young people into agriculture, the green economy, manufacturing, ICT, the creative industry and the hospitality industry, we will be creating entrepreneurs; otherwise, the biggest problem we are facing today is youth unemployment. It is a time bomb. I have always said that countries that fail to tackle youth unemployment are just waiting for the young people to explode one day and we should not be waiting for that to happen.

Mr Speaker, it is a national security risk and we must find a way to do that. We can only do that when we behave like what the Americans did. In America, for example, the Americans started putting in the minds of the young people something they call the American dream, where they become employers. So, every young American man or young woman wants to become the employer and not the employee. So, they give their time and their energy for about two to three years and all they are thinking of is what they can do to also become the employer,

because at the end of the day, if one is just an employee, they are just working for somebody to make the resources and to make the money off them. They are using other people's time, energy, brains, and everything to make the money. So, they think that, if, for example, a person becomes a farm manager and can employ two or three people, they become the employer. If a person becomes a carpenter in that place and they are producing furniture that Parliament or Ghanaians can buy, or that can be exported, then they become the employer. If a person is even doing tailoring job, where they can employ six or seven people, then they become the employer. If a person is doing boat construction, where fishermen can buy their boat, then they become the employer. If a person has a young farm where they can employ labourers to work for them, then they become the employer. If a person has a "chop bar", a *kenkey* bar, or a *waakye* joint, where they become the employer, they can employ other people.

So, Mr Speaker, I am clear in my mind that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, thank you. I thought that for this one, we do not give—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, the time is being controlled automatically.

Yes, Minority Leadership?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, I yield to Hon Asafo-Adjei.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Asafo-Adjei, you have the floor.

Mr Nana Asafo-Adjei: Mr Speaker, I would also want to commend the Maker of the Statement, the Member of Parliament for Krachi-Nchumuru.

Mr Speaker, this is a very important Statement and it is important because of the category of people we are talking about. These are the most vulnerable people within society. It appears as though when all the political parties are making campaigns, our buffer, our stock or the point where we fall more for votes is the youth. It happens that it is because of the vulnerability of these youth that we use them for some of these things. Now, this Statement is diverting our mind to the critical state and nature of the fact that we find a lasting solution to funding and creating jobs and opportunities for them.

Mr Speaker, there are some youth developmental funds and projects. We have the Youth Employment Agency (YEA), the National Youth Authority, the National Entrepreneurship and Innovation Programme and the Ghana Enterprise Agency. All these agencies, groups and institutions are youth-funded institutions.

Mr Speaker, we will notice that the National Youth Authority has a source of funding, which is the parliamentary allocations. We have about 5 per cent District Assemblies Common Fund that

is earmarked for the National Youth Authority. At the YEA, we have a statutory allocation that goes to them and we have 80 per cent of Communication Service Tax that are earmarked for the YEA. We have 10 per cent of the District Assemblies Common Fund that is earmarked for YEA and then we have 5 per cent of the Ghana Education Trust Fund that is also earmarked for YEA.

Mr Speaker, when we look at all the funds that I mentioned, the YEA, the Youth Employment, the National Entrepreneurship and Innovation Programme and all the programmes that I mentioned, they have a certain source of funding. For me, it is about how we are integrating all these sources of funding and directing them towards achieving a certain purpose we are looking at.

Mr Speaker, if we are not careful, we would have a fragmented youth development fund scattered across the country all over based on governmental decisions, policies and priorities, and we may not necessarily achieve what we want to achieve in the future.

Mr Speaker, the New Patriotic Party (NPP), will come and decide to develop another model to fund or create jobs for the youth and then set up a fund. The National Democratic Congress (NDC) will also come tomorrow and would also want to do a separate or different thing to also find a way to develop the youth or create jobs for the youth. What is important is how are we working and integrating all these things so that we have a certain central development

fund and a dedicated, committed pool to support our youth and create opportunities for them? If we are not careful and we do not do some of these things well and our youth come to lose hope in the system, that is when we will find a lot of brain drain. Young men and women are leaving the shores of Ghana to go somewhere to find jobs where they believe that there is a better and proper system that will provide for them or that will take care of them. If we are not careful, we will find people misusing and abusing the system that we have because it is very fragmented.

Mr Speaker, I commend the Maker of the Statement once again and I think that we must look at this as a House. If the Committee on Youth and Sports or the Committee on Employment, Labour Relations and Pensions would go much more into this and see if we can have a certain integrated pool or a certain joint dedicated fund, instead of fragmenting, separating and scattering all the funds across because of individual or party priorities, then we will be looking at a point where the country can be bold and be certain about a certain dedicated fund committed by successive governments to be used to develop the youth.

2:48 p.m.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I want to thank you for the opportunity.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, just to humbly draw your attention to—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will have to take two from your Side.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Great. Thank you.

Mr Frank Afriyie (NDC — Afadjato South): Mr Speaker, thank you so much. Let me also proceed to add my voice to the speaker who had just ended to commend the maker of the Statement on bringing to the fore an issue as relevant as the establishment of a Youth Development Fund. The youth constitute the future of this nation and any attempt to get our governance structure right, we must not exclude them. Getting them involved will mean that we are answering the challenges of the future.

Mr Speaker, as is colloquially said, when these youth are idle, the devil finds a job for them. Data from the Ghana Statistical Service, Revised Edition, in 2024 puts youth unemployment at a staggering rate of 32 per cent. Indeed, as has earlier on been observed, this is like a time bomb. Matters of job, matters of livelihood and the rest must be taken seriously. Now is the time. Fortunately for us, establishing a fund of this nature, we might not be reinventing the wheel anyway, as very practical and useful examples exist in other jurisdictions.

Mr Speaker, the most important thing for us to note is that plethora of funds that are youth-based exist. Unfortunately, the crux of the issue here has to do with application or how we apply them. Often, partisanship takes the central stage in our consideration. The mode in which we dish out some of these funds, hard-earned funds of the ordinary citizen to party cronies, is at the heart of the reason we have not been able to find a

very useful source of funding for youth entrepreneurship.

Mr Speaker, as the maker of the statement rightly said, the youth are gifted with talents, they have energy, they are mentally resourceful, and indeed they are prepared to take the challenge in order to secure their own future. Ours is to help them by ensuring that this House takes the bold decision of coming out with a fund that insulates itself from the partisanship, the needless partisan consideration that we have suffered in time past, regardless of regimes.

But I think that the most important news for me has to do with the fact that we have a regime today that is extremely committed to matters of the youth. Indeed, H.E. the President, in the course of his campaign, has outlined his roadmap for equipping the youth with entrepreneurship under the National Apprenticeship Programme. Indeed, we are rolling out equipment to enable and make this particular campaign promise a reality.

Mr Speaker, we have again identified that one of the difficulties that youth encounter, particularly for which reason they seek funding, is about land acquisition and agribusiness in general. Currently, the President has encouraged any youth, particularly youth in my constituency, Afadjato, where we go into cocoa production, that land acquisition, land preparation, seedlings, fertilizer, every equipment, every input and tool that will enable them to cultivate cocoa farms are ready and they will be supplied with it.

Mr Speaker, the President desires us to ensure that within the next four years, we are able to create about 200,000 hectares of cocoa farms. And this is what the youth must take advantage of. Indeed, under the Feed Ghana Programme, we are rolling out a lot of incentives and support systems for the youth. So, it is not just a matter of establishing the Fund alone, but it is also about the youth taking advantage of all the policies of the system as we have them currently. Mr Speaker, when we are able to do this—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Edem Agbana?

Mr Eric Edem Agbana (NDC — Ketu North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to this Statement. Let me commend the maker of the Statement for making this very important Statement on behalf of the youth of this country. Currently, more than 50 per cent of Ghana's population are under the age of 35. What it means is that our population is largely youth-driven. For that matter, it is important for us as a country to adequately support and prepare and build the capacity of these young people.

Mr Speaker, successive governments have invested heavily in youth-led policies and programmes. But many of these programmes, we must admit, have not really impacted in empowering young people and solving the problem of unemployment because of how it is structured. From 1993 until today, every single government that we have had has dedicated some fund or has allocated

money to support youth-led programmes. We recently had Youth Employment and Entrepreneurship in Productive Sector (YESp), we have the National Entrepreneurship and Innovation Programme (NEIP), and all of that. But, if we are to do a critical analysis, cost-benefit analysis, of all of these programmes, the question is, with all the money that we have invested in programmes like YESp, NEIP, how many young entrepreneurs today can we point to that have been very successful because of this support? It is simply because over the years, these support schemes are done in such a way that they are either episodic initiatives or they are done just to satisfy a certain political agenda momentarily.

Mr Speaker, when we go to countries like Kenya, Namibia, and so where youth funds really work, where many young entrepreneurs are supported and see the benefits of this support, the way it is structured, it is such a way that, Mr Speaker, we will see really the outcome, the impact of these programmes. This Statement is calling for Government to establish a national youth development fund. What this fund will do is that, Mr Speaker, it will provide a buffer where young entrepreneurs who are doing so well, but because maybe they do not have access to capital or loans from the banks and because they do not have the collateral that is needed to go to the commercial market, they can rely on this buffer in order to grow their business.

Mr Speaker, we have many young entrepreneurs today, the likes of Caveman, who is producing very

beautiful watches that even our President is wearing his brand. We have the likes of Horseman shoes, and Giddins, also producing beautiful shoes. We have many other young entrepreneurs who are doing very well, but they need support. We have the likes of Bondaana, who is designing very beautiful shirts that even presidents of other countries are wearing, beyond even our President alone. As I speak, our Minister for Energy and Green Transition wears Bondaana. But, Mr Speaker, all these young entrepreneurs cannot boast of any support from the State to expand.
[Interruption]

I do not know what Mr Speaker is wearing, but it looks very Ghanaian. Mr Speaker, thank you for wearing made in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, back to the point. We need to, as a country, be very strategic about investing in young people, beyond setting up Funds where we are giving GH¢2,000, GH¢3,000, and GH¢5,000 to young entrepreneurs. The question is, all that we have doled since 1993, how many successful entrepreneurs have we produced from any of these funds? If it is possible, Mr Speaker, even if it means supporting a young entrepreneur with GH¢1 million, GH¢10 million, GH¢50 million, and we are sure that that entrepreneur will take over the entire market, create jobs, and in the end pay back the State, I think it is more sustainable.

2:58 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I want to plead that this Statement be given the necessary attention. This is because today, across

our constituencies, the greatest challenge that we are confronted with is unemployment.

In conclusion, the support for and setting up a fund for young people should not be treated as a social intervention but as should be treated as a strategic investment that will solve even the problem of instability in the future. Mr Speaker, with these few words, I want to plead with you and the House to seriously consider pushing this agenda so that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have come to the end of that Statement. The last but not the least is in the name of Hon Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong.

Hon Members, I would direct that this Statement be published in the *Hansard*.

Challenges of the Cashew Industry in Ghana and the way Forward

Mr Akwasi Gyamfi Onyina-Acheampong (NPP — Kwabre East): Mr Speaker, the cashew industry in Ghana is vital to the country's agriculture sector, greatly contributing to export earnings and rural communities. The industry is regulated by the Tree Crops Development Authority under the TCDA Act, 2019 (Act 1010). Cashew trees grow in seven of Ghana's sixteen regions; however, they are mostly cultivated in Bono, Bono East, Ahafo, Northern, and Savannah Regions. The cashew season runs from December to June, with the peak from March to May, which is considered the main season.

Sampa, Techiman, Wenchi, Drobo, Nkrankwanta, Kameseikrom, Bole, Dormaa, Japeikrom and Bamboi are known for cashew farming.

Mr Speaker, over 300,000 farmers are directly involved in cashew cultivation, supporting a network of about 200,000 people working as buying agents, dealers, transporters, and retailers. Ghana is currently the third-largest exporter of raw cashew nuts worldwide, exporting an estimated 180,000 metric tonnes annually and earning approximately US\$300 million in export revenue. Significant volumes of cashew also come from neighbouring La Côte d'Ivoire and Burkina Faso, with the former supplying close to 50 per cent of the exports between March and May.

Mr Speaker, a well-regulated cashew industry has numerous advantages, including:

Stable Market Prices. A regulated industry can help stabilise market prices, reducing fluctuations and uncertainty for farmers, processors, and exporters. This stability can lead to increased investor confidence and more predictable income for industry stakeholders.

Increased Export Earnings. By ensuring consistent quality and quantity, Ghana can increase its export earnings from the cashew industry. This can contribute to the country's foreign exchange reserves and improve its balance of payments.

Industrialisation. A well-regulated cashew industry can lead to the

development of processing industries, creating value-added products and increasing the industry's contribution to Ghana's Gross Domestic Product (GDP). This can also lead to the transfer of technology and skills, promoting industrialisation and economic growth.

Job Creation. The cashew industry can create employment opportunities for people in rural areas, both in farming and processing. Jobs are also created through the cashew value chain with job openings created in purchasing, drying, quality checking, and shipment. This helps to reduce unemployment and poverty, contributing to improved living standards.

Income Generation. A well-regulated cashew industry can generate income for farmers, processors, and exporters, improving their livelihoods and contributing to local economic development. A regulated industry also helps to stabilise income for processors, reducing the risks associated with market fluctuations. This can lead to increased investment in processing infrastructure and improved product quality.

Improved Farmer Welfare. By providing support and resources to farmers, a well-regulated industry can improve their welfare and productivity. This can lead to increased farmer incomes, better working conditions, and improved livelihoods.

Traceability and quality standards. Traceability and quality standards reassure consumers about the safety and quality of cashews. Industry stakeholders

reduce the risk of product recalls, fines, and reputational damage. Traceability and quality standards help streamline processes, reducing waste and improving productivity.

Reduced Post-Harvest Losses. By implementing best practices and standards, a well-regulated industry can reduce post-harvest losses, increasing the quantity and quality of cashews available for processing and export. This can lead to increased efficiency, reduced waste, and improved profitability for industry stakeholders.

Mr Speaker, notwithstanding the potential of the cashew industry, the industry faces numerous structural and operational challenges that threaten its growth. One of the most urgent issues is the sharp decline in production, with a 30 per cent drop recorded in 2024 compared to the previous year, decreasing from 230,000 metric tonnes in 2023 to 161,000 metric tonnes in 2024. This decline has partly been caused by disease and pest infestations, along with inadequate extension services and a lack of knowledge among farmers about improved farming techniques. These issues have hampered productivity and lowered both the quality and quantity of yields.

Mr Speaker, additionally, market access remains limited, and farmers face price instability at the farm gate level. While the Tree Crop Development Authority (TCDA) has set the current market price at GH¢15.00 per kilogram (minimum), farmers received as low as GH¢ 7 in 2024, down from GH¢8.50 in

2023. This wide gap between farm gate and market prices discourages farmers and exposes them to exploitation and income insecurity.

Mr Speaker, the industry also struggles with low local processing capacity, with only about 6 per cent of raw cashew nuts processed domestically. Most raw cashew is exported to countries like Vietnam and India for processing, missing out on the value addition that could significantly boost national revenue. Analysts estimate that increased investment in local processing could generate over US\$700 million for the Ghanaian economy. Furthermore, smuggling and poor post-harvest handling practices further reduce the industry's profitability and international competitiveness.

Mr Speaker, unregulated buyers, also known as briefcase buyers, pose a significant challenge to the cashew industry in Ghana. These buyers, typically foreign merchants, offer high prices for raw cashew nuts (RCN), drawing supplies away from local processors and buyers. This practice not only undermines government policies but also distorts the markets, undermines Ghana's value addition agenda like and threatens the local cashew processing industry. Most of these buyers do not even have the required permits to work in Ghana and are often chased by immigration officials along the borders. The Association of Cashew Processing Processors Ghana (ACPG) warns that unregulated exports could lead to the collapse of the local cashew processing industry, resulting in job losses and economic instability.

Mr Speaker, it is important to note that Ghana's Cashew Industry faces several sustainability issues that impact its long-term viability and environmental footprint. Some of the challenges include:

Environmental concerns. Pesticide misuse and greenhouse gas emissions from cashew production and processing are significant environmental concerns. For instance, thousands of tons of cashew nuts are wasted annually, contributing to substantial greenhouse gas emissions.

Social Issues. Inadequate rural infrastructure, rural poverty, child labour, and insufficient empowerment of women are some of the social challenges facing Ghana's Cashew Industry. Women play a critical role in cashew production, processing, and packaging, but often lack support and resources.

Climate Change. Climate change has an impact on the agriculture sector, and the cashew Industry is no exception. Rising temperatures, excessive droughts, and changing weather conditions significantly reduce cashew yield and impact the farmers' livelihood.

There are also no formalised farming training programs that training programs to educate farmers on the best farming practices that promote organic farming, agroforestry, and climate-smart agriculture. There is also little or no additional or alternative livelihood programs for the cashew farming activities.

To unlock the full potential of the cashew sector, a multi-faceted approach is necessary to:

Invest in Extension Services and Farmer Training: Strengthening agricultural extension services and training farmers in modern farming and post-harvest handling techniques are crucial for boosting productivity and improving product quality.

Enhance Local Processing Capacity. Ghana must prioritise investments in processing infrastructure to keep more of the cashew value chain within the country. The 2024 partnership between Ghana and La Côte d'Ivoire offers a promising opportunity to scale up joint processing and marketing strategies.

Strengthening the regulatory role of the TCDA. Mechanisms should be put in place to ensure fair and predictable prices for farmers. The laws governing the regulation of the cashew industry must be enforced. This will help address pricing disparities and limit the power of middlemen or reduce the activities of unregulated operators (briefcase operators)

Improve Market Access and Combat Smuggling. Expanding domestic and international market connections through trade promotion, certification schemes, and anti-smuggling efforts can help stabilise supply chains and safeguard farmer incomes.

Promote Research and Development. Investing in research to develop disease and pest-resistant cashew varieties and

improve farming practices will enhance resilience and long-term productivity.

In conclusion, Mr Speaker, I suggest forming a special board to oversee and regulate Ghana's Cashew Industry, similar to how we control Ghana Cocoa Board (COCOBOD) and Ghana Gold Board (GOLDBOD). While Ghana's cashew industry has great promise, achieving its full potential will require coordinated efforts among the government, industry stakeholders, and development partners. With the right policies and targeted investments, the cashew sector can become a powerful engine for rural development, export diversification, and economic growth.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I call on the last Statement, standing in the name of Mr Misbahu Mahama Adams, MP Mion.

Ramadan, Extreme Heat in Northern Ghana and a Call for Climate Action.

Mr Misbahu Mahama Adams (NDC — Mion): Mr Speaker, I rise today to extend my warmest wishes to my fellow Muslim brothers and sisters across Ghana and beyond as we prepare to observe the sacred month of Ramadan—a period of deep reflection, devotion, and self-discipline.

Mr Speaker, as we embark on this month of fasting, we must acknowledge the unusual heatwave currently affecting Northern Ghana and many other parts of the country. This unbearable heat in the Region has always exacerbated the challenges of fasting, posing severe

health risks and threatening livelihoods notably children, the elderly, and those fasting. This is a clear manifestation of climate change.

Mr Speaker, Islam encourages self-care and moderation, and it is crucial that Muslims take necessary precautions during this Ramadan. I strongly advise all fasting individuals to:

Stay Hydrated – Drink enough water between Iftar (breaking of fast) and Suhoor (pre-dawn meal) to prevent dehydration.

Avoid Excessive Sun Exposure – Minimise outdoor activities, especially during peak hours of heat.

Consume Nutritious Meals – Eat fruits and foods rich in water to sustain energy levels.

Above all, let us read Quran the more as the Ramadan is a month of Quran.

Mr Speaker, beyond these personal precautions, we must also reflect on the environmental changes contributing to this extreme heat.

Prophet Muhammad Sallallahu Alaihi Wasallam (S. A. W.), that is, may the peace and blessings of Allah be upon him, strongly encouraged tree planting, saying: "If a Muslim plants a tree or sows seeds, and then birds, or a person, or an animal eats from it, it is regarded as a charitable gift (sadaqah) for him." (Hadith, Bukhari & Muslim).

Mr Speaker, the Prophet Muhammed (S.A.W,) again admonishes us to plant more trees as the benefits of trees are endless to the environment and to us as *Sadaqatul Jaariah* when we are no more. This timeless guidance remains relevant today. Trees deliver essential ecosystem by providing shade, cooling the environment, and mitigating climate change.

The situation calls for urgent and decisive climate action by the Government and relevant stakeholders. I therefore make a clarion call to the Minister of State, Climate Change and Sustainability, the Minister for Environment, Science and Technology, and the Ghana Tree Crop Development Authority to intensify efforts in climate adaptation and mitigation strategies.

The Ghana Tree Crop Development Authority must take proactive steps in promoting agroforestry and sustainable land management practices to counteract the effects of extreme temperatures. Additionally, the stakeholders should spearhead innovative climate resilience programmes, including afforestation and sustainable irrigation projects, to safeguard our communities from the harsh impacts of climate change. Moreover, I urge the Ministry of Climate Change and Sustainability to advance policies that encourage renewable energy adoption and climate-smart agricultural practices.

Mr Speaker, as we seek blessings in this holy month, let us also heed our responsibility as stewards of the earth. Let us pray, fast, and act by taking care

of our health, protecting our environment, and promoting sustainability in our communities. Therefore, I urge all stakeholders particularly in Northern Ghana, to embrace tree planting initiatives as a long-term strategy to combat the rising temperatures and desertification affecting our region.

May this Ramadan bring peace, good health, and prosperity to all Ghanaians.

Thank you, Mr Speaker for this opportunity.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko (NPP — Effia): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Statement made by my Brother, Mr Misbahu Adams, and also to take advantage to wish our Muslim brothers, *Ramadan Kareem*. In my constituency, Effia, we have a huge Muslim population. So, I am in full support of the Statement that he has made, particularly linking climate change in the area of heat to its effects on the people during the Ramadan fasting.

Mr Speaker, I have had quite a good experience with the North for over the past years, for about 20 years and beyond. When we go to the North, yes, we have always noted that the temperatures there have been very high compared to the South, but recently, when we visited there as a Committee, you could literally feel the heat, even in a time when we did not expect the heat to be as strong as it is today. So, it clearly tells us that there are certain things that are going on, which is affecting the climate as we see today. So, we all have a collective responsibility to do something about it.

Mr Speaker, he mentioned deforestation. There has always been a clarion call on our country. How are we protecting our forests? Our forests have not had any strategic government intervention or any government policy to protect it. It has even been compounded by the activities of illegal mining. Previous lands that were used for agricultural purposes today, we have seen the impact of illegal mining activities. Because they are unapproved in the area of legalisation, they go in there and destroy our forest reserve. It is an important situation we need to look at as a Government and as a Parliament, so that we can take strategic actions in minimising the effect of deforestation and then also the activities of illegal mining.

Mr Speaker, to just conclude because of time, I would want to urge this House that collectively, we have a responsibility to look at our laws that governs our climate and our environment. The Committee on Environment, Science and Technology, which, of course, I am a part of, should also look at some interventions and engagement with the sector Ministry to make sure that at the end of the day, we get the best for this country.

Mr Speaker, to our Muslim brethren as they go towards the final lap of their fasting period, I want to wish them very well. We can see that some of their faces are shining. The way Hon Suhuyini is brightening today in the House, I believe that is going well for him. Please, the advice is to avoid the heat during the high temperatures so that they can reserve some energy.

Mr Speaker, without saying more, I would want to commend the maker of the Statement for this very important Statement made. I thank you.

Alhaji Yusif Sulemana (NDC — Bole Bamboi): Mr Speaker, let me sincerely thank you for this opportunity and to also thank my brother for this historic, important and relevant Statement. Fasting as enshrined in Quran chapter 2 verse 183, says that: “*Yaa ayyuhal lazeena aamanoo kutiba 'alaikum Siyaamu kamaa kutiba 'alal lazeena min qablikum la'allakum tattaqoon*”. To wit, “O’ ye who believe, fasting is prescribed for you, as it was prescribed for those before you, so that you may gain self-restraint.”

This is very important. — *[Interruption]*— You can open the Quran, and that is why I am saying that open to Quran chapter 2 verse 183.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please address the chair.

3:11 p.m.

Alhaji Y. Sulemana: Mr Speaker, the relevance of this verse is the linkage between the Christian fast and the Muslim fast. Coincidentally, this year, the Catholics started their 40-day fasting period with the Muslims, and it is not just by coincidence; it has a historic meaning. Mr Speaker, the Quran says: “as it was prescribed for those before you...”. Who are those before you? Those before you are the Christians, the Jews. When the Prophet Muhammad (S.A.W.), peace be upon him, left Mecca and was going to Medina, he went to Medina and met the

Christians, the Jews, and they were already fasting. So, he started fasting and copying what they were doing until this verse was revealed to him, telling him that the fasting that they are emulating is also prescribed for you, as it was prescribed for those before you.

Mr Speaker, today we fast for 30 days. There are some who fast for seven days. Indeed, Moses, before the commandment, had to fast. And so there is some relationship between today’s fasting as Muslims and the Christian fasting. That tells us that we are together, we are the same people, and we are worshipping the same God. Monotheism; that is how we see it, the worship of one God.

Mr Speaker, in the month of Ramadan, we have so many beautiful events that every Muslim will want to be associated with. In this month, we are talking about what we call Tahajjud, an additional supplementary prayer. When we do it, we feel closer, and we feel that spiritually, we are growing. In this month, we have what we call the Laylatul Qadr—We are using this opportunity to invite our Colleagues that tomorrow, inshallah, we will be observing the Night of Power.

Let me thank the Rt Hon Speaker for this opportunity. The Leadership of Parliament have over the years, supported us as Muslims to be able to celebrate this Night of Power. And so tomorrow, all our Colleagues, whether you are a Muslim or not, you are all invited. Let us celebrate this Night. It is a Night that Allah says is better than a thousand years. He says that in Qu’ran chapter 97, which states:

In the name of Allah, Most Gracious,
Most Merciful;

Bismillaahir Rahmaanir Raheem

1. *Innaa anzalnaahu fee lailatil qadr*
2. *Wa maa adraaka ma lailatul qadr*
3. *Lailatul qadri khairum min alfee shahr*
4. *Tanaz zalul malaa-ikatu war roohu feeha bi izni-rab bihim min kulli amr*
5. *Salaamun hiya hattaa mat la'il fajr*

To summarise this, Mr Speaker, God says that within this Night of Power, there is this Night, which is better than a thousand months. And there is a reason God said that in the Quran. Apart from the Prophet Muhammad, all other prophets had lived longer, but he lived 63 years, and his Umar was worried why he lived 63 years. His concern was that he wanted to live longer so that he could serve my God, and God is telling him not to be bothered. There is a particular Night between the 20th and 30th of the month of Ramadan, and that Night is worth a thousand years. That is the comfort that was given to Prophet Muhammad and his followers.

Mr Speaker, there are so many benefits of Ramadan. The health practitioners will tell you that when you fast, you even lose weight —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your time is up.

Yes, Minority Leadership?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, this year, something very strange happened; Lent and Ramadan coincided. Lent started the same day as Ramadan. So Mr Speaker, it is a very big spiritual push for humanity. When the maker of the Statement brought this issue of Ramadan to our attention and the benefit thereto, he also drew our attention to extreme heat in the north and talked about the fact that we have destroyed our environment, and we need to plant more trees.

Mr Speaker, earlier we had heard from Hon Agyinsam, who had spoken about entrepreneurs and micro, small, medium-sized enterprises, and also emphasised the need for us as a country to build an entrepreneurial hub of Africa so that we promote private sector engagement. Mr Speaker, in his Statement, he had also called upon us to create a platform to encourage innovation, productivity, and also create a healthy competition for our entrepreneurs. That would obviously create a platform for the private sector so that more of our youth get jobs to do.

Mr Speaker, connecting this Statement to what the Member for Mion just said, we are all aware how *galamsey* is destroying the environment. And the Member talked about the need for us to ensure we do tree planting. The Statement spoke about climate change and then gave us the background to climate change that, as a result of the destruction of our forest cover, we are experiencing extreme heat, and there is a need, therefore, to plant trees. I am saying that directly connected to this is the need to create an opportunity for our youth, especially so when we are aware

that one of the factors destroying our forest cover is *galamsey*.

Mr Speaker, from what he said, the climatic conditions are becoming worse as a result of *galamsey*.

3:18 p.m.

That is the main source of the destruction of our forest cover, where trees felling, where our water bodies are being destroyed and people are even cutting down their cocoa trees because of the attraction of *galamsey*.

So Mr Speaker, the call is the right call and coming at this very holy month, where we are fasting as Christians and fasting as Muslims, he could not have emphasised the more, that we need to take our environment as a treasured asset, not to destroy our environment. And for the areas that we know *galamsey* activities have destroyed the forest cover, Government will need to invest in tree planting. He talked about tree crop. We in this House, passed a law, the Tree Crop Development Authority Act, 2019 (Act 1010), and we established that institution. Recently, they had a summit, Tree Crop Summit at the Accra International Conference Centre and the Majority Leader and my good self were there to make some remarks.

Mr Speaker, we have to encourage our youth to go into tree crop farming. Coconuts, mango and other tree crops should be seen as a major source of employment. I was in the Bono area over the weekend and they were talking about cashew. We seem to have forgotten about some of these cash crops and we are not putting in policies to attract the

youth in that direction. This is the reason for which they go on the *galamsey* path and destroy our environment.

Mr Speaker, the Member for Mion has drawn our attention to an important matter and we do not have to be partisan about it. He could not have said it better. So, I would propose that this Statement should not just end here. Mr Speaker, my proposal is for you to make a referral of this important Statement to the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources for them to sift a statement out of this all-important Statement from our Colleague from Mion, so that there can be a national policy to guide the youth and create that space, the resources, the funding for the many who would want to see it as an alternative source of employment. Otherwise, they would continue to see illegal mining, otherwise known as *galamsey*, as their main source of bread. And we all know the effects of that, as was ably stated by the Member who made the Statement.

Mr Speaker, that said, I would want to rest my case and commend him highly for the industry that went into the Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Majority Leadership?

Yes, Hon Suhuyini, you have the floor.

Alhaji Suhuyini Sayibu Alhassan (NDC — Tamale North): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to this very important Statement made by my Brother and Colleague from the Mion Constituency, Hon Misbahu. Mr Speaker, the Statement could not have

come at an appropriate time and I just wish to reiterate, quoting Quran chapter 2, verse 185, where we are told, “Allah intends for you ease and does not intend for you hardship”. *[Interruption]* It is to conserve the time that I have to speak.

Mr Speaker, it is for good reason that this provision in the Quran is used to urge members of the faith to understand that the religion is not to be a burden upon them. And that is why, even with fasting, even though it is prescribed and it is one of the five pillars of Islam, there are still exemptions. There are temporary exemptions and there are permanent exemptions and exemptions that sometimes relate to health. If you are unhealthy to fast, fasting is not compulsory to you. There are, however, remedies that are recommended. For example, the feeding of — In the past, it was said a slave, but now, you can feed people who are fasting, or you help people who are fasting to break their fast, or the needy or poor in society. And with that, you get the same reward as if you had fasted if you are exempted as a result of ill health. I would have wished that we got the opinion on the medical importance of fasting, but since we are limited by the numbers this afternoon, Mr Speaker, I want to stress on a point that was made earlier by my colleague Yusif when he quoted from the Quran and talked about self-restraint.

Mr Speaker, the cornerstone of Ramadan and fasting is to teach self-restraint in every aspect of life. It talks about discipline. Mr Speaker, you can equate this to what is said in the Bible, Corinthians Chapter 6 verse 12, where— *[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]*— I quote correctly. *[Laughter]* Where it is said that all things are lawful — I am not talking about Psalm 23. I am talking about Corinthians.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the expression “I do not quote like Dr Mahamudu Bawimia” is ordered to be expunged from the records as though it does not exist.

Alhaji S. S. Alhassan: Mr Speaker, I am guided.

Mr Speaker, in the book of Corinthians, we are told that “all things are lawful unto me, but all things are not expedient”. Mr Speaker, this is to tell us and that is what we are supposed to learn from Ramadan and from fasting, that even though you may have the right and the capacity to do certain things, you should be able to exercise some self-restraint. At least for 30 days in a month, be disciplined. And the hope is that — life coaches would even tell you that to change a habit or an attitude, you need to stay with that behaviour for about 30 days or less and then you can replace an old habit with a new one. So, we are taught that at least for 30 days in a year, we should be disciplined in all aspects of life. I do not want to give some examples. We should be disciplined and the anticipation is that even after the 30 days, we can continue with that disciplined life. So, it is not just denying ourselves food and water, it is also to deny ourselves some of the pleasures of life that we know are not religious or good for us.

So, Mr Speaker, on this note, I hope and pray that we would all get the benefits of this holy month of Ramadan and we will come out of this holy month.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have exhausted all the Statements scheduled on the *Order Paper*.

3:28 p.m.

All Statements scheduled on the *Order Paper*. Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, by my reckoning, we have done exactly five hours so we are entirely in your hands.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members—

Yes?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, this Side of the House has a major concern. In this House, we deal with public Business that emanate from the Government. There are also initiatives of Members of Parliament, not limited to Statements and Questions, but also Motions and we must find space to deal with all of them. Mr Speaker, the Minority has had a pending Motion in this House. This is the ninth month. Any time this Motion had been scheduled to be taken, we are told that it be shifted for another time. I would want to put on record that the Motion is of such importance that this House of Parliament cannot continue to let it pend. It is about the unemployment situation. It is about mass dismissal of Ghanaians who otherwise were in the employ of state institutions. The Motion was moved, seconded, and the Majority Chief Whip was the first contributor on that Side and it was adjourned for us to continue the debate so that Mr Speaker can make a final ruling on it. Mr Speaker, the youth out there who have been sitting home for over a year are looking up to this House for a voice. It cannot be that any time the

Minority raises this matter, the Majority would find a way, subtly, to deny us the opportunity of concluding a debate on this matter.

Second, Mr Speaker, there is another Motion that has to do with Gold Board and Bank of Ghana, which was admitted and duly advertised. We have raised this several times with our Colleagues. They promised that we would deal with it. We get into the Chamber, an excuse is given one way or the other, and we do not deal with it. I am saying this so that nobody would say that the Minority Side slept on its rights. We have said this over and over again, and I will plead with the Majority Chief Whip—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, we have agreed to sit on Monday to exhaust Questions and Statements. That was the basis for us sitting on Monday. We have not agreed to sit on Monday to take Motions or do any other Business. So, a situation where the agreement is to sit on Monday and take Questions and exhaust all the Statements, and we are going to discuss a pending Motion, I have a difficulty about it. Because at the Conclave, the plea was that we should sit on Monday to exhaust all the pending Questions and Statements. So having exhausted that, I think the time is due for us to adjourn, and the House is accordingly adjourned till Tuesday 10th March, 2026 at 12 noon.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 3:31 p.m. till Tuesday, 10th March, 2026 at 12 noon.

Editor's Note

This *Official Report* was corrected by the House on 16th March, 2026.

Column 29, paragraph 2, “there” was replaced with “then”.

Column 8, last paragraph, “the Minority” was inserted after “you” and “so” before “allow”.